

DO NOT OPEN THIS TEST BOOKLET UNTIL YOU ARE ASKED TO DO SO**TEST BOOKLET SERIES****Test Code:
2203****TEST BOOKLET
GENERAL STUDIES
TEST – 3****C****Time Allowed : Two Hours****Maximum Marks : 200****INSTRUCTIONS**

1. IMMEDIATELY AFTER THE COMMENCEMENT OF THE EXAMINATION, YOU SHOULD CHECK THAT THIS TEST BOOKLET *DOES NOT* HAVE ANY UNPRINTED OR TORN OR MISSING PAGES OR ITEMS, ETC. IF SO, GET IT REPLACED BY A COMPLETE TEST BOOKLET.
2. ENCODE CLEARLY THE TEST BOOKLET SERIES CODE **A, B, C** OR **D** AS THE CASE MAY BE IN THE APPROPRIATE PLACE IN THE ANSWER SHEET.
3. You have to enter your Roll Number on the Test Booklet in the Box provided alongside this line. *DO NOT* write *anything else* on the Test Booklet.
4. This Test Booklet contains 100 items (questions). Each question is printed both in **Hindi** and **English**. Each item comprises four responses (answers). You will select the response which you want to mark on the Answer Sheet. In case you feel that there is more than one correct response, mark the response which you consider the best. In any case, choose **ONLY ONE** response for each item.
5. You have to mark all your responses **ONLY** on the separate Answer Sheet provided. See directions in the Answer sheet.
6. All items carry equal marks.
7. Before you proceed to mark in the Answer Sheet the response to various items in the Test Booklet, you have to fill in some particulars in the Answer Sheet as per instructions sent to you with your admission certificate.
8. After you have completed filling in all your responses on the Answer Sheet and examination has concluded, you should hand over to the Invigilator *only the Answer Sheet*. You are permitted to take away with you the Test Booklet.
9. Sheets for rough work are appended in the Test Booklet at the end.
10. **Penalty for wrong answers:**
THERE WILL BE PENALTY FOR WRONG ANSWERS MARKED BY A CANDIDATE IN THE OBJECTIVE TYPE QUESTION PAPERS.
 - (i) There are four alternatives for the answer to every question. For each question for which a wrong answer has been given by the candidate, **One-Third** of the marks assigned to that question will be deducted as penalty.
 - (ii) If a candidate gives more than one answer, it will be treated as a **wrong answer** even if one of the given answers happens to be correct and there will be same penalty as above to that question.
 - (iii) If a question is left blank, i.e., no answer is given by the candidate, there will be no **penalty** for that question.

DO NOT OPEN THIS TEST BOOKLET UNTIL YOU ARE ASKED TO DO SO*Note:* Hindi version of the instructions is printed on the front cover of this Booklet.



1. With reference to the Special Drawing Rights (SDR), consider the following statements:

1. It is an international reserve asset, created by the International Monetary Fund (IMF).
2. The value of the SDR is calculated from a weighted basket of major currencies.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

2. The introduction of the Green Revolution was associated with which of the following problems?

1. Depletion of groundwater table
2. Loss of soil fertility
3. Reduction of Seed replacement ratio to zero
4. Widespread fungal infections in surrounding crops

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 4 only (b) 3 and 4 only
(c) 1 and 2 only (d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

3. Consider the following statements:

1. Energy Efficiency Enterprise (E3) Certifications Programme is an accreditation process focused on the Cement industry.
2. The adoption of the E3 Certification is currently compulsory in nature.
3. The E3 Certificate is awarded to those enterprises whose specific energy consumption will be 25% lower than the national baseline.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 3 only (d) 1 and 3 only

4. Consider the following statements:

1. The Consumer Price Index (CPI) is released by the National Statistical Office (NSO).
2. The CPI for Industrial Workers (IW) is compiled by the Labour Bureau in the Ministry of Labour and Employment.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

5. Consider the following statements about Core Investment Companies:

1. Core Investment Companies (CICs) are specialized Non-Banking Financial Companies (NBFCs).
2. Infrastructure Leasing and Financial Services Ltd (IL&FS) is a Core Investment Company.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

6. Consider the following statements:

1. Sangay volcano is one of the highest active volcanoes in the world.
2. Active volcanoes have a recent history of eruptions and they are likely to erupt again.

Which of the following statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

7. With reference to the Sahitya Akademi award, Consider the following statements:

1. It is a literary honour that is conferred annually by Sahitya Akademi.
2. Languages that are not mentioned in the Indian Constitution are not considered for the Award.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

8. With reference to the Green Bonds, consider the following statements:

1. It is a debt instrument with which capital is raised to fund environmentally sustainable projects.
2. The green bonds have been crucial in increasing financing to certain sunrise sectors.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2



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9. Consider the following statements about the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act of 2002:
1. It is a tool for recovering Non-Performing Assets.
 2. This act is applicable to cooperative banks as well as commercial banks.
- Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
10. Consider the following statements:
1. NITI Aayog releases the ranking of Aspirational Districts of the country.
 2. Champions of Change dashboard is related to the Aspirational Districts scheme.
- Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
11. Which of the following statements is/are correct regarding Seabuckthorn?
1. It is a rare plant species recently rediscovered from the Sikkim Himalayas.
 2. It prevents soil erosion and helps preserve floral biodiversity.
 3. It has been widely used for treating stomach, heart and skin problems.
- Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 2 only (b) 1 and 3 only
(c) 2 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3
12. Project RE-HAB has been launched in Karnataka for:
- (a) eradicating foot and mouth disease in animal
 - (b) developing fisheries sector in the country
 - (c) mitigating human-elephant conflict
 - (d) providing financial help to marginalized people
13. Consider the following statements regarding the Government of NCT of Delhi (Amendment) Act, 2021?
1. It gives discretionary powers to the L-G except in matters where the Legislative Assembly of Delhi is empowered to make laws.
 2. It states that “government” in the National Capital Territory of Delhi meant the Lieutenant-Governor of Delhi.
- Which of the following statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
14. With reference to the National Cadet Corps, consider the following statements:
1. The National Cadet Corps falls under the purview of the Ministry of Home Affairs.
 2. It enrolls cadets at the high school and college levels and also awards certificates on completion of various phases.
- Which of the following statements given above is/are **NOT** correct?
- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2
15. With reference to the Inter-Parliamentary Union, consider the following statements:
1. It aims to promote parliamentary dialogue worldwide and work for peace and cooperation among the people.
 2. India is not a member of the Inter-Parliamentary Union.
- Which of the following statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2





16. With reference to Foreign Portfolio Investment (FPI), consider the following statements:

1. It is often referred to as hot money.
2. It does not provide the investor with direct ownership of financial assets.
3. It is part of a country's current account in its Balance of Payments.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 only
(c) 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

17. With reference to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010 (FCRA), consider the following statements:

1. Any NGO that wishes to receive foreign funding needs to register with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) under the FCRA.
2. Every asset purchased with foreign funds must be in the name of the NGO and not its office bearers or members.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

18. Consider the following statements:

1. The Economic Census is done by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).
2. Economic Census is the complete count of all economic establishments located within the geographical boundary of the country and abroad.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

19. According to the World Air Quality Report, 2020, which of the following are the major sources of India's air pollution?

1. Transportation
2. Biomass burning for cooking
3. Electricity generation
4. Construction
5. Waste burning
6. Episodic agricultural burning

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2, 3 and 5 (b) 2, 3, 4 and 5
(c) 1, 2, 3, 5 and 6 (d) 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 and 6

20. With reference to the Medical Termination of Pregnancy (Amendment) Act, 2021, consider the following statements:

1. Every state government is required to constitute a Medical Board.
2. The opinion of the two registered medical practitioners is essential for a pregnancy to be terminated after 24 weeks.
3. Unmarried women are not covered under the act.

Which of the following statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

21. International Lunar Research station (ILRS) is a joint program of :

- (a) Russia and China (b) China and Japan
(c) USA and India (d) USA and UK

22. With reference to the 'Midday Meal Scheme', consider the following statements:

1. It is a centrally sponsored scheme.
2. It is one of the world's largest school meal programmes.
3. Its main objective is the universalization of primary education.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3



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23. Consider the following statements about a Blank-Cheque-Company:
1. It is a firm that is specifically set up with the objective of acquiring a firm in a particular sector.
 2. It is also known as a Special Purpose Acquisition Company (SPAC).
- Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
24. Consider the following statements regarding Nutrient-Based Subsidy (NBS) Regime:
1. Fertilizers are provided to the farmers at the subsidized rates based on the nutrients contained in them.
 2. It is being implemented by the Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare.
- Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
25. Consider the following statements about Ayushman Bharat:
1. Health and Wellness Centres are an important component of Ayushman Bharat.
 2. The Socio-Economic Caste Census 2011 is used to identify the beneficiaries of the health insurance scheme.
- Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
26. Consider the following statements regarding the Purchasing Managers Index (PMI):
1. It is an indicator of business activity in the services sectors only.
 2. In PMI parlance, a score of 55 will mean growth in business activity.
- Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
27. Which of the following power projects is/are **NOT** located on the Chambal river?
1. Gandhi Sagar Dam
 2. Srisailem Dam
 3. Rana Pratap Sagar Dam
 4. Sardar Sarovar Dam
- Select the correct answer using the code given below:
- (a) 1, 2 and 3 only (b) 1 only
(c) 2 and 4 only (d) 1 and 3 only
28. With reference to the Anangpal II of the Tomar Dynasty, consider the following statements:
1. He was succeeded by his son Prithviraj Chauhan.
 2. He was the ruler of present-day Delhi and Haryana in between the 8th-12th centuries.
- Which of the following statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
29. With reference to the Ranthambore Tiger Reserve, consider the following statements:
1. It lies at the junction of the Aravali and Vindhya hill ranges.
 2. It comprises both National Parks and Sanctuaries.
- Which of the following statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
30. With reference to World Trade Organization (WTO), consider the following statements:
1. Currently, public distribution programmes of developing countries are included under Amber Box.
 2. The Trade Policy Review Mechanism (TPRM) was the result of the Uruguay Round multilateral trade negotiations.
- Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2





31. Consider the following statements:

1. Open Market Operations (OMOs) is the buying and selling of bonds issued by the Government in the open market.
2. OMOs is the one of the qualitative tools used by RBI to minimise the impact of liquidity condition on the interest rate and inflation rate levels.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

32. Consider the following statement:

1. Preferential Trade Agreement is the first stage of economic integration.
2. In a Preferential Trade Agreement tariffs are not abolished completely.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

33. Which of the statements is/are correct regarding Gram UJALA Programme?

1. Under this program, high quality LED bulbs will be distributed in both urban and rural areas.
2. The programme will be financed entirely through carbon credits.
3. It is the first such programme in India.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 and 3 only (b) 1 only
(c) 2 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

34. Which of the following statements is correct about 'Indian basket of crude oil'?

- (a) The Indian basket of crude oil defines the benchmark price at which crude oil is sourced by Indian refiners.
- (b) The Indian Basket of Crude oil is decided on the basis of the price of the London-based Brent.
- (c) It defines the benchmark price at which Indian refiners sell petroleum products in the market.
- (d) None of the above.

35. Consider the following statements:

1. White label ATM is owned by the bank but its operation and maintenance is outsourced to a third party.
2. Brown label ATM is owned and operated by a non-banking entity while cash is provided by the sponsor bank.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

36. Consider the following statements about Rural Infrastructure Development Fund (RIDF):

1. It provides low cost funds to State governments for rural infrastructure projects.
2. It has been set up within NABARD

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

37. Consider the following statements:

1. Ken-Betwa Link Project aims to transfer surplus water from the Ken river in Madhya Pradesh to Betwa in Uttar Pradesh.
2. Betwa River passes through Panna tiger reserve.
3. Rajghat, Paricha and Matatila dams are over Ken river.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 2 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3



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38. Consider the following statements:

1. Both Anti Dumping as well as Countervailing duty are a type of customs duty.
2. Imposition of Anti-Dumping measures is considered an unfair trade practice by the World Trade Organisation, and is not permitted.
3. Anti Dumping duty is imposed on goods that have received government subsidies in the originating or exporting country.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 2 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

39. With reference to the Fiscal Responsibility and Budgetary Management Act 2003, consider the following statements:

1. As per this act, the Government shall end its borrowing from the RBI except for temporary advances.
2. The act set a target of reducing the revenue deficit to 3% of the GDP and eliminating the fiscal deficit by 2008-09.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

40. With reference to 'Technology and Innovation Report 2021', consider the following statements:

1. It is released by the World Economic Forum.
2. As per the report, India was the biggest 'overperformer' in frontier technologies.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

41. Consider the following statements regarding the Ease of Living Index (EoLI) 2020:

1. It is released by NITI Aayog.
2. Shimla has been ranked 1st in EoLI Index 2020.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

42. With reference to Asola Bhatti Wildlife Sanctuary, consider the following statements:

1. Recently an "eco-sensitive zone" tag has been given to it.
2. The sanctuary acts as a water recharge zone for Delhi, Faridabad, and Gurugram.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

43. Consider the following statements:

1. WIPO Copyright Treaty and the WIPO Performances and Phonograms Treaty are collectively known as the WIPO Internet Treaties.
2. Special 301 report is published by the World Intellectual Property Organization.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

44. With reference to the Government borrowings, consider the following statements:

1. Seventh schedule of the Indian Constitution gives powers of raising foreign loans to both Centre and State.
2. State Governments need to obtain the consent of the Centre for raising fresh loans.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

45. With reference to the Minor Forest Produce (MFP), consider the following statements:

1. The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs announces Minimum Support Price for Minor Forest Produce.
2. The Minor Forest Produce includes leaves, dyes and raisins.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2



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46. Consider the following statements:

1. The Gulf of Bothnia is on the west and it opens in the Baltic Sea.
2. Along with the Norwegian peninsula, the whole system becomes a Nordic Country.

Identify the country using the information provided above:

- (a) Sweden (b) Iceland
(c) Finland (d) Denmark

47. Consider the following statements:

1. Core inflation is an inflation measure which takes into account temporary price volatility.
2. Headline inflation is an inflation measure which excludes food and energy prices.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

48. Recently seen in news, “AsterX” is a:

- (a) NASA’s Mission to Space
(b) Military exercise
(c) Russia’s new Space Station
(d) China’s new Satellite

49. With reference to European Free Trade Association (EFTA), consider the following statements:

1. EFTA consists of Switzerland, Norway, Iceland and Liechtenstein.
2. None of the EFTA member States are member of European Union.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

50. With reference to the “Better than Cash Alliance”, which of the following statements is **NOT** correct?

- (a) “Better than Cash Alliance” is a partnership for the transition from cash to digital payments.
(b) “Better than Cash Alliance was created in 2015 by PayTM.

- (c) The Alliance has 75 members which are committed to digitising the payments.
(d) None of the above.

51. Which of the following committee(s) is/are related to reforms in Banking sectors?

1. Narasimham Committee
2. P J Nayak Committee
3. Abhijit Sen Committee

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

52. With reference to different modes of electronic money transfer, consider the following statements:

1. Electronic Clearing Service (ECS) is used for transactions which are repetitive and periodic in nature.
2. National Automated Clearing House is used to facilitate transactions between different banks.
3. Transactions only upto Rs. 2,000 can be done using contactless card payment.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1, 2 and 3 (b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 2 only (d) 2 and 3 only

53. Consider the following statements:

1. Pradhan Mantri Vaya Vandana Yojana (PMVVY) is a social security scheme to protect elderly persons against a future fall in their interest income due to uncertain market conditions.
2. Both public and private insurance companies are party to implementing Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY).
3. Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PMJAY) is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS).

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3



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54. Identify the river from above given facts:

1. In the district of Sambalpur of the state of Odisha a dam is built over it.
2. Ib, Hasdeo, and Ong are major tributaries of it.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- | | |
|--------------|--------------|
| (a) Mahanadi | (b) Godavari |
| (c) Cauvery | (d) Krishna |

55. The report 'Food Waste Index' is published by:

- (a) World Economic Forum
- (b) World Bank
- (c) UNICEF
- (d) UNEP

56. To double the income of farmers by the year 2022, government set up an Inter-Ministerial Committee. Which of the following have been identified as the source of income growth of the farmers by the committee?

1. Improvement in crop productivity
2. Shift from farm to non-farm occupations
3. Diversification towards high-value crops
4. Increase in the cropping intensity
5. Improvement in livestock productivity

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- | | |
|------------------------|------------------------|
| (a) 1, 3 and 4 only | (b) 1, 2, 3 and 4 only |
| (c) 1, 3, 4 and 5 only | (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5 |

57. With reference to Geographical Indication (GI) tag, consider the following statements:

1. GI is governed by the WTO's agreement on Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPS).
2. The registration of a geographical indication in India is valid for a period of 10 years only.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- | | |
|------------------|---------------------|
| (a) 1 only | (b) 2 only |
| (c) Both 1 and 2 | (d) Neither 1 nor 2 |

58. Which of the following countries borders Israel?

- | | |
|--------------|------------|
| 1. Egypt | 2. Jordan |
| 3. Syria | 4. Lebanon |
| 5. Palestine | |

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 5 only
- (b) 2, 3 and 4 only
- (c) 1, 3 and 5 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

59. Consider the following statements.

1. National Food Security Act, 2013 (NFSA) provides a legal basis for the public distribution system (PDS).
2. Commission for Agricultural Costs & Prices (CACP) that recommends minimum support price (MSP) is a statutory body set up through an Act of Parliament.
3. Sugar cane pricing is governed by the Sugarcane (Control) Order, 1966 issued under the Essential Commodities Act.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 1 and 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

60. With reference to the bridge 'Maitri Setu', which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. The bridge is built over the Feni River.
2. It is constructed by the National Highway Authority of India.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2



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61. Which of the following pairs are correctly matched?

Survey/Index/ Report	Released by
1. All India Survey on Higher Education	– Department of Higher Education, MHRD
2. School Education Quality Index	– Department of School Education & Literacy MHRD
3. Performance Grading Index (PGI)	– NITI Aayog
4. Programme for International Students Assessment	– OECD

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 2 and 4 only (b) 3 and 4 only
(c) 1 and 4 only (d) 1, 2 and 3 only

62. Consider the following statements:

1. A technical recession is when a country faces a continuous decline for four consecutive quarters in the Gross Domestic Product (GDP).
2. The growth rate in terms of Gross Value Added (GVA) is GDP minus net product taxes.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

63. Consider the following statements about Monetary Policy Committee (MPC):

1. It was established under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934.
2. The Finance Secretary of India is the chairman of the committee.
3. The MPC is responsible for determining the Inflation Target.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 2 and 3 only (d) 3 only

64. Which of the following is/are the functions of the Permanent Indus Commission?

1. To study and report to the two Governments on any problem relating to the development of the waters of the rivers.
2. To solve disputes arising over water sharing.
3. To undertake, once in every ten years, a general tour of inspection of the Rivers for ascertaining the facts.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 3 only
(b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

65. If the relationship between per capita consumption and per capita national income shows a high elasticity of consumption then what does it imply?

- (a) The growth rate of consumption per capita is more than that of per capita income.
- (b) The growth rate of consumption per capita is almost the same as that of per capita income.
- (c) The growth rate of consumption per capita is less than that of per capita income.
- (d) The growth rate of consumption per capita is volatile in comparison to that of per capita income.

66. With reference to One Nation One Ration Card Scheme, consider the following statements:

1. This will allow a beneficiary to buy food grains from any fair price shop in India through biometric authentication.
2. A Public Distribution System Network (PDSN) has been established to implement national level portability.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2



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67. With reference to the Sovereign Gold Bond Scheme, consider the following statements:

1. The bonds are issued by the Reserve Bank of India on behalf of the Central Government.
2. The gold bonds are sold only to resident Indian entities.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

68. With reference to Current Account Deficit (CAD), consider the following statements:

1. Current account records exports and imports in goods and services only.
2. CAD can be reduced by curbing non-essential imports such as gold, mobiles, and electronics.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

69. Which of the following are **NOT** the members of the selection committee for the Gandhi Peace Prize?

1. The Chief Justice of India
2. Chief Ministers of the states
3. Leader of the Single largest Opposition Party
4. Lok Sabha Speaker
5. Rajya Sabha Chairman

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 4 only (b) 1, 3, 4 and 5 only
(c) 1, 3 and 4 only (d) 2 and 5 only

70. Which of the following are the objectives of UDAY Scheme?

1. Distribution of affordable LEDs
2. Reduction of cost of power generation
3. Free of cost electricity connections to the poor families
4. Enforcing financial discipline on DISCOMs

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 3 only (b) 2 and 4 only
(c) 1, 2 and 4 only (d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

71. Consider the following statements regarding Infrastructure Investment Trust (InvIT):

1. It enables direct investment of money from institutional investors only.
2. They are regulated by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI).

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

72. Consider the following statements about Cess:

1. A cess is an additional tax imposed with a purpose of raising funds for a specific task.
2. Article 250 of the Indian Constitution prohibits the sharing of cess with the State Governments.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

73. Consider the following statements:

1. India's Forex Reserves include the Foreign Currency Assets (FCA) and Gold reserves only.
2. The Foreign Currency Assets are expressed in dollar terms.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

74. With reference to the 'Simlipal Biosphere Reserve', consider the following statements:

1. It has been a part of the 'UNESCO World Network of Biosphere Reserve' since 2009.
2. It is a part of the Simlipal-Kuldiha-Hadagarh Elephant Reserve.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2



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75. Consider the following statements:

1. National Cyber Security Strategy 2020 is the first-ever Cyber Security policy made in India.
2. Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC) is the premier R&D organization for carrying out R&D in IT, Electronics, and associated areas.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

76. With reference to recommendations of resource allocation by 15th Finance Commission, consider the following statements:

1. It has recommended maintaining the vertical devolution as 50:50 between States and the Union.
2. For horizontal devolution of resources, the criteria 'income distance' has maximum weightage.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

77. With reference to the Priority Sector Lending (PSL), consider the following statements:

1. The RBI mandates only scheduled commercial banks and Regional rural banks to lend under PSL.
2. The Regional rural banks have to allocate 100% of their Adjusted Net Bank Credit (ANBC) to PSL.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

78. Which of the following are the reasons which caused balance of payment crisis of 1991?

1. Higher prices of oil at international level
2. Decline in private remittances from overseas Indian workers
3. Loss of confidence in the government
4. Post-independence interventionist development strategy
5. Industrial licensing requirements

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 5 only (b) 1, 2, 4 and 5 only
(c) 1 and 2 only (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

79. Consider the following statements regarding Quasar:

1. A quasar is a quasi-stellar radio source.
2. They are only found in galaxies having supermassive black holes.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

80. With reference to Rashtriya Uchchatar Shiksha Abhiyan (RUSA), consider the following statements:

1. It is a Center Sector Scheme.
2. Its main objective is to increase the enrolment ratio of students in the primary level of schooling.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

81. With reference to the Minimum Alternate Tax (MAT), consider the following statements:

1. MAT was introduced due to an increase in the number of zero tax paying companies.
2. Only domestic companies in India are covered under the provision of MAT.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

82. Consider the following statements regarding impact of currency depreciation in India:

1. Increment in the country's export activity.
2. Travelling to India gets costly.
3. People receiving remittances from abroad are gainers.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 2 and 3 only (b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3



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83. With reference to Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR), consider the following statements:

1. The concept of CSR is governed by Corporate Social Responsibility Act, 2013.
2. The CSR provisions are applicable to companies with an annual turnover of 1,000 crore.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

84. With reference to the 'Policy of Neutrality', which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. It is an international treaty that prevents wars and hatred among nations.
2. Austria is the only permanently neutral power.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

85. With reference to the Asset Reconstruction Company (ARC), consider the following statements:

1. It is a specialized financial institution that buys the Non Performing Assets (NPAs) from banks and financial institutions.
2. The SARFAESI Act, 2002 provides the legal basis for the setting up of ARCs in India.
3. The ARC has been proposed to be set up with the equity contribution from the government.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 3 only
(c) 1 and 2 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

86. Consider the following statements:

1. It is a Centralised Payment System of the RBI.
2. In this system, the transactions received up to a particular time are processed in batches.
3. There is no limit on fund transfer through it.

The above statements most appropriately describe which of the following Systems of Payments?

- (a) National Electronic Fund Transfer (NEFT) system
(b) Real Time Gross Settlement (RTGS) System
(c) Cheque Truncation System (CTS)
(d) Express Cheque Clearing System (ECCS)

87. 'Purple Revolution' is related to:

- (a) Lavender
(b) Purple Rice
(c) Butterfly
(d) Bt-Brinjal

88. With reference to negative interest rate policy, consider the following statements:

1. Under this policy, banks are required to pay interest for parking excess reserves with the central bank.
2. This policy has been adopted by countries experiencing hyperinflation due to excess liquidity in the system.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

89. Consider the following statements:

1. It is located in Nagpur District and a river passes through the middle of the Sanctuary.
2. It is the joint pride of both Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra.
3. It is one of the important sites of Important Bird Areas (IBA) and Tiger Reserve.

Identify the Wildlife Sanctuary from the above-given facts:

- (a) Pench Wildlife Sanctuary
(b) Kuno Wildlife Sanctuary
(c) Ratapani Wildlife Sanctuary
(d) Koyna Wildlife Sanctuary





90. Recently 'Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav' was celebrated to mark the occasion of :

- 75th anniversary of India's Independence
- 75th anniversary of Dandi March
- 50th anniversary of Civil Disobedience Movement
- 50th anniversary of Quit India Movement

91. The Fifteenth Finance Commission has used which of the following criteria to arrive at the states' share in the divisible pool of taxes?

- Population
- Tribal population
- Size of state's GDP
- Industrialization factor

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- 1 only
- 1, 2 and 3 only
- 2, 3 and 4 only
- 1, 2, 3 and 4

92. With reference to the 'Aravalli Range', consider the following statements:

- It was one of the oldest folding mountain ranges.
- Guru Shikhar is the highest peak of the range.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- 1 only
- 2 only
- Both 1 and 2
- Neither 1 nor 2

93. With reference to the Consumer Welfare Fund (CWF), consider the following statements:

- It was set up under the Central Goods and Services Tax (CGST) Act, 2017.
- The fund will be operated by the Ministry of Finance.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- 1 only
- 2 only
- Both 1 and 2
- Neither 1 nor 2

94. Consider the following statements:

- A Micro Finance Institution (MFI) provides loans to people who do not have any access to banking facilities.
- In India, loans granted for less than Rs. 5 lakh are considered as microloans.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- 1 only
- 2 only
- Both 1 and 2
- Neither 1 nor 2

95. Consider the following statements regarding Shigmo festival:

- Shigmo festival is the spring festival in Goa celebrated by the Konkani diaspora of Goa.
- It is celebrated by the name of Kamadahan in Maharashtra.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- 1 only
- 2 only
- Both 1 and 2
- Neither 1 nor 2

96. Suez Canal connects:

- Mediterranean Sea and the Red Sea
- Black Sea and the Red Sea
- Caribbean Sea and Mediterranean Sea
- Black Sea and Mediterranean Sea

97. Consider the following statements about Exchange Traded Funds (ETFs):

- ETFs are traded on the stock exchange just like stocks.
- The Bharat Bond ETF will result into reduction of borrowing cost of the government.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- 1 only
- 2 only
- Both 1 and 2
- Neither 1 nor 2



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98. Which of the following are correct about Government securities (G-secs)?

1. G-secs can be issued by the Central Government only.
2. The Central Government can issue both treasury bills and bonds while the State Governments can issue only bonds.
3. G-secs are risk-free gilt-edged instruments.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 and 3 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 2 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

99. Consider the following statements:

1. Ways and Means Advances (WMA) scheme was introduced to meet mismatches in the receipts and payments of the government.
2. The government can avail immediate cash from the RBI under WMA scheme.

3. The government doesn't have to pay any interest to RBI for withdrawal under the WMA scheme.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 2 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

100. Which of the statements given below about Kaziranga National Park is/are correct?

1. It is recognized as an Important Bird Area by BirdLife International.
2. It has the highest population of tigers in India.
3. River Diphlu passes through this Park.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3



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**Test Code:
2203**

(English Version)

**ANSWER & EXPLANATION
GENERAL STUDIES**

TEST – 03

C

ANSWERS

Q. No.	Answers	Q. No.	Answers	Q. No.	Answers	Q. No.	Answers
1	(c)	26	(b)	51	(a)	76	(b)
2	(c)	27	(c)	52	(b)	77	(d)
3	(c)	28	(b)	53	(d)	78	(d)
4	(c)	29	(c)	54	(a)	79	(c)
5	(c)	30	(c)	55	(d)	80	(d)
6	(c)	31	(a)	56	(d)	81	(a)
7	(a)	32	(c)	57	(c)	82	(c)
8	(c)	33	(c)	58	(d)	83	(b)
9	(c)	34	(a)	59	(d)	84	(d)
10	(c)	35	(b)	60	(c)	85	(c)
11	(c)	36	(c)	61	(c)	86	(a)
12	(c)	37	(a)	62	(b)	87	(a)
13	(b)	38	(a)	63	(a)	88	(a)
14	(a)	39	(a)	64	(b)	89	(a)
15	(a)	40	(b)	65	(b)	90	(a)
16	(a)	41	(b)	66	(c)	91	(a)
17	(b)	42	(c)	67	(c)	92	(c)
18	(c)	43	(a)	68	(b)	93	(a)
19	(d)	44	(b)	69	(d)	94	(a)
20	(a)	45	(b)	70	(b)	95	(a)
21	(a)	46	(c)	71	(b)	96	(a)
22	(d)	47	(d)	72	(a)	97	(c)
23	(c)	48	(b)	73	(b)	98	(b)
24	(a)	49	(c)	74	(c)	99	(b)
25	(c)	50	(b)	75	(b)	100	(c)



1. (c)

Explanation:

- **Special Drawing Rights (SDR)** is an **international reserve asset, created by the International Monetary Fund (IMF)** in 1969 to supplement its member countries' official reserves. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The SDR is neither a currency nor a claim on the IMF. Rather, it is a potential claim on the freely usable currencies of IMF members. SDRs can be exchanged for these currencies.
- The value of the SDR is calculated from a **weighted basket of major currencies**, including the **US Dollar**, the **Euro**, the Japanese **Yen**, the Chinese **Yuan**, and the British **Pound**. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- The interest rate on SDRs or (SDRi) is the interest paid to members on their SDR holdings.

2. (c)

Explanation:

The Green Revolution led to the following:

- The continuous use of groundwater for tubewell irrigation has **reduced the water-table**. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- **Loss of soil fertility** due to increased use of chemical fertilizers. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- Seed Replacement Ratio is a measure of how much of the total cropped area was sown with certified seeds in comparison to farm saved seeds. This has increased as farmers started using certified seeds more and more. **Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.**
- The high yielding variety of crops and use pesticides, insecticides etc. has helped reduce fungal infections **Hence, statement 4 is NOT correct.**

3. (c)

Explanation:

Energy Efficiency Enterprise (E3) Certifications Programme:

- The Ministry of Power has launched the "Energy Efficiency Enterprise (E3) Certifications Programme for the Brick Manufacturing Sector".
- E3 certification is an accreditation process focused on the Brick industry. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- The certification will be provided by the Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE).

- The adoption of the E3 Certification is currently voluntary for the Brick industry. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
- The E3 Certificate is awarded to those enterprises whose specific energy consumption will be **25% lower** than the national baseline. **Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

4. (c)

Explanation:

- The **Consumer Price Index (CPI)** measures price changes from the perspective of a retail buyer. It is released by the **National Statistical Office (NSO)**. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The CPI calculates the difference in the price of commodities and services such as food, medical care, education, electronics, etc.
- The CPI has several sub-groups including food and beverages, fuel and light, housing and clothing, bedding and footwear.
- **Four types of CPI are as follows:**
 1. CPI for Industrial Workers (IW).
 2. CPI for Agricultural Labourer (AL).
 3. CPI for Rural Labourer (RL).
 4. CPI (Rural/Urban/Combined).
- **CPI for Industrial Workers (IW)**, CPI for Agricultural Labourer (AL) and CPI for Rural Labourer (RL) are compiled by the **Labour Bureau in the Ministry of Labour and Employment**. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
 - CPI (Rural/Urban/Combined) is compiled by the National Statistical Office (NSO) in the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation.

5. (c)

Explanation:

- Core investment companies are **non-banking financial companies (NBFCs)** holding not less than 90% of their net assets in the form of investment in equity shares, preference shares, bonds, debentures, debt or loans in group companies. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- Reserve Bank of India (RBI) had constituted a working group to improve CICs corporate governance standards.
- The recommendations were made by the Working Group to Review Regulatory and Supervisory Framework for Core Investment Companies (Tapan Ray Committee).

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- Experts have been seeking a review of CIC guidelines ever since defaults by Infrastructure Leasing and Financial Services Ltd (IL&FS), a **large systemically important core investment company**. Hence, **statement 2 is correct**.
- Unlike NBFCs which are required to constitute board level committees, no such standards are mandated for CICs. The same director could be part of boards of multiple companies in a group, including CICs.
- Further, the committee also recommended preparing consolidated financial statement and ring-fencing the boards of CICs by excluding employees or executive directors of group companies from its board.
- Currently, CICs are not required to submit off-site returns or statutory auditors' certificate (SAC). Off-site returns or statutory auditors' certificate are submitted to RBI by NBFCs where the auditor certifies that the company continues to operate as an NBFC. The committee recommended that off-site returns may be designed by RBI and prescribed for CICs on the lines of other NBFCs.

6. (c)

Explanation:

- Sangay volcano is one of the highest active volcanoes in the world and one of Ecuador's most active ones. Hence, **statement 1 is correct**.
- Sangay is the southernmost stratovolcano (a volcano built up of alternate layers of lava and ash) in the northern volcanic zone of the Andes.
- Active volcanoes have a recent history of eruptions and they are likely to erupt again. Hence, **statement 2 is correct**.

7. (a)

Explanation:

Sahitya Akademi Award:

- Sahitya Akademi award **established in 1954**, is a literary honour that is conferred annually by Sahitya Akademi, India's National Academy of letters. Hence, **statement 1 is correct**.
- The Sahitya Akademi award is the **second-highest** literary honour by the Government of India, after the **Jnanpith award**.
- Akademi gives 24 awards annually to literary works in the languages it has recognized and an equal number of awards to literary translations from and into the languages of India.

- Besides the 22 languages enumerated in the Constitution of India, the Sahitya Akademi has recognised English and Rajasthani as languages in which its programme may be implemented. Hence, **statement 2 is NOT correct**.

8. (c)

Explanation:

- A green bond is a debt instrument with which capital is **raised to fund 'green' projects**, which typically include those relating to renewable energy, clean transportation, sustainable water management etc. Hence, **statement 1 is correct**.
 - A bond is a fixed income instrument that represents a loan made by an investor to a borrower (typically corporate or governmental).
 - Bonds traditionally pay a fixed interest rate (coupon) to investors.
- The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has put in place disclosure norms for issuance and listing of green bonds.
- Green bonds typically carry a lower interest rate than the loans offered by the commercial banks. With an increasing focus of foreign investors towards green investments, it could help in reducing the cost of raising capital.
- Green bonds have been **crucial in increasing financing to sunrise sectors** like renewable energy, thus contributing to India's sustainable growth. Hence, **statement 2 is correct**.
 - Sunrise industry is a term used for a sector that is just in its infancy but shows promise of a rapid boom.
 - The industry is typically characterized by high growth rates, high degree of innovation and generally has plenty of public awareness about the sector and investors get attracted to its long-term growth prospects.

9. (c)

Explanation:

The Supreme Court recently held that the provisions of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (SARFAESI Act) will be applicable to **cooperative banks, and not just commercial banks**. Hence, **statement 2 is correct**.



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- The SARFAESI Act was passed on **December 17, 2002**, in order to lay down processes to help Indian lenders recover their dues quickly.
- The SARFAESI Act essentially empowers banks and other financial institutions to **directly auction residential or commercial properties** that have been pledged with them to recover loans from borrowers.
- Before this Act took effect, financial institutions had to take recourse to civil suits in the courts to recover their dues, which is a lengthy and time-consuming process.
- As per the SARFAESI Act, if a borrower defaults on a loan financed by a bank against collateral, then the bank gets sweeping powers to recover its dues from the borrower. After giving a notice period of 60 days, the lender can take possession of the pledged assets of the borrower, take over the management of such assets, appoint any person to manage them or ask debtors of the borrower to pay their dues too, with respect to the asset. This recovery procedure saves banks and financial institutions a lot of time which otherwise would be long drawn out due to the intervention of courts.
- The first asset reconstruction company of India, **ARCIL**, was set up under this act.
- Banks utilize SARFAESI Act as an effective tool for **bad loans (Non-Performing Asset) recovery**. It is effective only against secured loans. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- It promotes the setting up of asset reconstruction companies (ARCs) and asset securitization companies (SCs) to deal with NPAs.

10. (c)

Explanation:

Aspirational districts programme, **launched in January 2018**, aims to transform districts that have shown relatively lesser progress in key social areas and have emerged as pockets of under-development. The ranking of aspirational districts is done every month. **The delta rankings takes into account incremental progress made by over 112 aspirational districts across six developmental areas**

- Health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion, skill development and basic infrastructure were the development areas that are taken into consideration for the ranking.

- The broad contours of the programme are Convergence (of Central & State Schemes), Collaboration (of Central, State level 'Prabhari' Officers & District Collectors), and Competition among districts driven by a mass Movement.
- **States as the main drivers, this program will focus on the strength of each district, identify low-hanging fruits for immediate improvement, measure progress, and rank districts.**
- The NITI Aayog releases the Delta ranking for the Aspirational Districts which measures the incremental progress made by them. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- Real Time Monitoring and ranking of districts is done through the **Champions of Change Dashboard**. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- 49 Key performance indicators (81 data points) have been identified, in consultation with Ministries across sectors of focus. The dashboard is designed, developed, and maintained by the Planning Department, Government of Andhra Pradesh.

11. (c)

Explanation:

Seabuckthorn

- It's a shrub that produces an orange-yellow coloured edible berry.
- In India, it is found above the tree line in the Himalayan region, generally in dry areas such as the cold deserts of Ladakh and Spiti.
- A major part is covered by this plant in Himachal Pradesh, Ladakh, Uttarakhand, Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- Seabuckthorn is a soil-binding plant that prevents soil erosion, checks siltation in rivers and helps preserve floral biodiversity. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- As a folk medicine, seabuckthorn has been widely used for treating stomach, heart and skin problems. **Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

12. (c)

Explanation:

A pilot project RE-HAB (Reducing Elephant-Human Attacks using Bees) has been launched in Karnataka which entails installing bee boxes along the periphery of the forest and the villages to mitigate human-elephant conflict. **Hence, option (c) is correct.**



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**13. (b)****Explanation:****Government of NCT of Delhi (Amendment) Act, 2021:**

- It amended Sections 21, 24, 33 and 44 of the 1991 Act.
- States that the “government” in the National Capital Territory of Delhi meant the Lieutenant-Governor of Delhi. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- It gives discretionary powers to the L-G even in matters where the Legislative Assembly of Delhi is empowered to make laws. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- It seeks to ensure that the L-G is “necessarily granted an opportunity” to give her or his opinion before any decision taken by the Council of Ministers (or the Delhi Cabinet) is implemented.
- It bars the Assembly or its committees from making rules to take up matters concerning day-to-day administration, or to conduct inquiries concerning administrative decisions.

14. (a)**Explanation:****National Cadet Corps**

- The NCC was formed in 1948 (on the recommendation of H.N. Kunzru Committee-1946) and has its roots in British era uniformed youth entities like University Corps or University Officer Training Corps.
- Currently, it has a strength of around 14 lakh cadets from Army, Navy and Air Force wings.
- The NCC falls under the purview of the Ministry of Defence and is headed by a Director-General of three-star military rank. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- It enrolls cadets at the high school and college levels and also awards certificates on completion of various phases. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

15. (a)**Explanation:****Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU):**

- IPU is an international organisation of **national parliaments**. It was established in **1889 in Paris**.
- It works with close co-operation with the United Nations (UN), regional parliamentary organisations, international intergovernmental organisations and non-governmental organisations for the arbitration of conflict.

- It aims to promote parliamentary dialogue worldwide and work for peace and cooperation among the people. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- 179 countries are members of the IPU along with India. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**

16. (a)**Explanation:**

- **Foreign portfolio investment (FPI)** consists of securities and other financial assets passively held by foreign investors. It **does not provide the investor with direct ownership of financial assets** and is relatively liquid depending on the volatility of the market. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
 - Examples of FPIs include **stocks, bonds, mutual funds, exchange traded funds, American Depositary Receipts (ADRs), and Global Depositary Receipts (GDRs).**
- **Other Details Related to FPI:**
 - FPI is **part of a country's capital account** and is shown on its **Balance of Payments (BOP)**. **Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.**
 - ◆ The BOP measures the amount of money flowing from one country to other countries over one monetary year.
 - ◆ The **Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)** brought **new FPI Regulations, 2019**, replacing the erstwhile FPI Regulations of 2014.
 - **FPI is often referred to as “hot money”** because of its tendency to flee at the first signs of trouble in an economy. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
 - ◆ **FPI is more liquid and less risky than Foreign Direct Investment.**

17. (b)**Explanation:**

- Since, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010 falls **under the purview of the Ministry of Home Affairs**, any NGO that wishes to receive foreign funding needs to register with it and not with the Reserve Bank of India. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- The Act permits only NGOs having a definite cultural, economic, educational, religious or social programme to accept foreign contribution, that too after such NGOs either obtain a certificate of registration or prior permission under the Act.

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**Registration and prior approval under FCRA:**

- In order to be registered under the FCRA, an NGO must be in existence for at least three years and must have undertaken reasonable activity in its field for which the foreign contribution is proposed to be utilised. Further, it must have spent at least INR 1,000,000 over three years preceding the date of its application on its activities. The Act imposes various conditions on the use of foreign funds and some of them are as follows:
 - All funds received by an NGO must be used only for the purpose for which they were received. Such funds must not be used in speculative activities identified under the Act.
 - Except with the prior approval of the Authority, such funds must not be given or transferred to any entity not registered under the Act or having prior approval under the Act.
 - Every asset purchased with such funds must be in the name of the NGO and not its office bearers or members.
- Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Reporting requirement:

- Every NGO registered or having prior approval under the Act must file an annual report with the Authority in the prescribed form. This report must be accompanied by an income and expenditure statement, receipt and payment account, and balance sheet for the relevant financial year.
- NGOs which violate the provisions of the FCRA are prohibited from receiving foreign funding under the act.

18. (c)**Explanation:****Economic Census-2019**

The Seventh Economic Census (7th EC) is being conducted by **Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI)** in 2019. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

- The MoSPI has partnered with CSC e-Governance Services India Limited, a Special Purpose Vehicle under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology as the implementing agency for 7th EC.
- Economic Census is the complete count of all economic establishment located within the geographical boundary of the country. It provides disaggregated information on various operational and structural variables of all establishments of the country. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

- The Census also provides valuable insight into geographical spread and clusters of economic activities, ownership pattern, persons engaged in all economic establishments of the country.
- The first Economic Census was undertaken in 1977. The Second EC was carried out in 1980 followed by the Third EC in 1990. The Sixth edition of Economic Census was conducted in 2013.

19. (d)**Explanation:**

- The **World Air Quality Report**, prepared by Swiss organisation **IQAir**, mentions that 22 of the top 30 most polluted cities globally are in India.
 - **Delhi has been ranked as the world's most polluted capital city** followed by **Dhaka (Bangladesh), Ulaanbaatar (Mongolia), Kabul (Afghanistan), Doha (Qatar)**.
 - Bangladesh has been ranked as the most polluted country followed by Pakistan and India.
 - **Ghaziabad is the second most polluted city in the world followed by Bulandshahar, Birsakh Jalalpur, Bhiwadi, Noida, Greater Noida, Kanpur and Lucknow.**
 - Major sources of India's air pollution include **transportation, biomass burning for cooking, electricity generation, industry, construction, waste burning, and episodic agricultural burning.**
- Hence, option (d) is correct.**

20. (a)**Explanation:****Medical Termination of Pregnancy (Amendment) Act, 2021:**

- Under the Act, a pregnancy may be terminated up to 20 weeks by a married woman in the case of failure of a contraceptive method or device.
- The Act allows unmarried women to also terminate a pregnancy for this reason. **Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.**
- Opinion of the State-level medical board is essential for a pregnancy to be terminated after 24 weeks in case of substantial foetal abnormalities. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
- Every state government is required to constitute a Medical Board. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

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- These Medical Boards will consist of the following members: (i) a gynaecologist, (ii) a paediatrician, (iii) a radiologist or sonologist, and (iv) any other number of members, as may be notified by the state government.

21. (a)

Explanation:

International Lunar Research station(ILRS) :

- **Russia and China** have agreed to build an ILRS, which would be built on the lunar surface and/or on the lunar orbit.
- Comprehensive scientific experiment base with the capability of long-term autonomous operation
- The station would carry out scientific research activities like lunar exploration and utilization, lunar-based observation, basic scientific experiments and technical verification. **Hence, option (a) is correct.**

22. (d)

Explanation:

Midday Meal Scheme

- **About:**
 - The Midday meal scheme (under the Ministry of Education) is a centrally sponsored scheme which was launched in 1995. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
 - It is the world's largest school meal programme aimed to attain the goal of universalization of primary education. **Hence, statements 2 and 3 are correct.**
 - Provides cooked meals to every child within the age group of six to fourteen years studying in classes I to VIII who enrolls and attends the school.
- **Objective:**
 - Address hunger and malnutrition, increase enrolment and attendance in school, improve socialisation among castes, provide employment at the grassroots level especially to women.
- **Quality Check:**
 - AGMARK quality items are procured, tasting of meals by two or three adult members of the school management committee.
- **Food Security:**
 - If the Mid-Day Meal is not provided in school on any school day due to non-availability of food grains or any other reason, the State Government shall pay food security allowance by 15th of the succeeding month.

23. (c)

Explanation:

- A blank-cheque company is an entity specifically set up with the objective of **acquiring a firm in a particular sector**. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
 - It is also known as **Special Purpose Acquisition Company (SPAC)**. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
 - A SPAC is a company that has no commercial operations and is formed strictly to raise capital through an Initiative Public Offering.
- The aim of this SPAC is to raise money in an Initial Public Offering (IPO), and at this point in time, it does not have any operations or revenues.
 - Once the money is raised from the public, it is kept in an escrow account, which can be accessed while making the acquisition.
 - If the acquisition is not made within two years of the IPO, the SPAC is delisted and the money is returned to the investors.

24. (a)

Explanation:

- Under the **Nutrient-Based Subsidy (NBS) Regime**, fertilizers are provided to the farmers at the subsidized rates based on the nutrients (**N, P, K & S**) contained in these fertilizers. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
 - The fertilizers which are fortified with secondary and micronutrients such as **molybdenum (Mo)** and **zinc** are given **additional subsidies**.
 - NBS policy intends to increase the consumption of P&K fertilizers so that optimum balance (**N:P: K= 4:2:1**) of NPK fertilization is achieved.
 - This would improve soil health and as a result, the yield from the crops would increase, resulting in enhanced income to the farmers.
 - Also, as the government expects rational use of fertilizers, this would also ease off the burden of fertilizer subsidy.
- It is being implemented from April 2010 by the **Department of Fertilizers, Ministry of Chemicals & Fertilizers**. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**



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**25. (c)****Explanation:**

Ayushman Bharat, a flagship scheme of Government of India, was launched as recommended by the National Health Policy 2017, to achieve the vision of Universal Health Coverage (UHC).

This scheme aims to holistically address the healthcare system at the primary, secondary and tertiary level. Ayushman Bharat adopts a continuum of care approach, comprising of two interrelated components, which are -

- Health and Wellness Centres (HWCs). **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PM-JAY)

Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY is the largest health assurance scheme in the world which aims at providing a health cover of Rs. 5 lakhs per family per year for secondary and tertiary care hospitalization to over 10.74 crores poor and vulnerable families.

- The households included are based on the deprivation and occupational criteria of Socio-Economic Caste Census 2011 (SECC 2011) for rural and urban areas respectively. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- PM-JAY is fully funded by the Government and cost of implementation is shared between the Central and State Governments.
- It covers up to 3 days of pre-hospitalization and 15 days post-hospitalization expenses such as diagnostics and medicines.
- There is no restriction on the family size, age or gender.
- All pre-existing conditions are covered from day one.
- Benefits of the scheme are portable across the country i.e. a beneficiary can visit any empanelled public or private hospital in India to avail cashless treatment.
- Services include approximately 1,393 procedures covering all the costs related to treatment, including but not limited to drugs, supplies, diagnostic services, physician's fees, room charges, surgeon charges, OT and ICU charges etc.
- Public hospitals are reimbursed for the healthcare services at par with the private hospitals.

26. (b)**Explanation:****Purchasing Managers Index**

Definition: PMI is an indicator of business activity- in the manufacturing and services sectors. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**

Calculation of PMI

- It is a **survey-based** measure that asks the respondents about changes in their perception about key business variables as compared with the previous month.
- It is calculated separately for the manufacturing and services sectors and then a composite index is constructed.
- The PMI is a number from 0 to 100.
 - PMI **above 50 represents an expansion** when compared to the previous month; **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
 - PMI **under 50 represents a contraction**, and
 - A reading **at 50 indicates no change.**
 - If PMI of the previous month is higher than the PMI of the current month (as is the case mentioned above), it represents that the **economy is contracting.**
- The PMI is usually **released at the start of every month.** It is, therefore, considered a **good leading indicator** of economic activity.

27. (c)**Explanation:****Chambal river:**

- It is one of the most pollution-free rivers in India.
- It enters U.P. and flows for about 32 km before joining the Yamuna River in Etawah District.
- It is a rainfed river and its basin is bounded by the Vindhyan mountain ranges and the Aravallis. The Chambal and its tributaries drain the Malwa region of northwestern Madhya Pradesh.
- **Tributaries:** Banas, Kali Sindh, Parbati.
- **Main Power Projects/Dam: Gandhi Sagar Dam, Rana Pratap Sagar Dam, Jawahar Sagar Dam, and Kota Barrage.**
- **Srisailem Dam is on Krishna river and Sardar Sarovar Dam is on Narmada river. Hence, option (c) is correct.**

28. (b)**Explanation:****Anangpal II:**

- Anangpal II, popularly known as Anangpal Tomar, belonged to the Tomar dynasty.
- He was the founder of Dhillika Puri, which eventually became Delhi.
- Multiple inscriptions and coins suggest Anangpal Tomar was the ruler of present-day Delhi and Haryana in between the 8th-12th centuries. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**



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- He had built the city from ruins and under his supervision, Anang Tal Baoli and Lal Kot were constructed.
- Anangpal Tomar II was succeeded by his grandson Prithviraj Chauhan. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**

29. (c)

Explanation:

Ranthambore Tiger Reserve:

- Ranthambore Tiger Reserve lies in the eastern part of **Rajasthan state in Karauli and Sawai Madhopur districts**, at the **junction of the Aravali and Vindhya hill ranges**. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- It comprises the **Ranthambore National Park** as well as **Sawai Mansingh and Keladevi Sanctuaries**. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- The vegetation includes grasslands on plateaus and dense forests along the seasonal streams.

30. (c)

Explanation:

- Recently, the final session of India's **seventh Trade Policy Review (TPR)** concluded at the World Trade Organization (WTO) in Geneva, Switzerland.
 - The TPR is an important mechanism under the WTO's monitoring function in which member countries' trade and related policies are examined by the WTO with an aim to contribute towards improved adherence to WTO rules.
- **Currently, public distribution programmes of developing countries are included under trade-distorting Amber Box measures** that attract reduction commitments of WTO. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- India with the group of developing countries is demanding that the programmes for food security purposes be exempted from subsidy reduction commitments of WTO.
- India has repeatedly demanded a permanent solution for public stockholding issues.
- **The Trade Policy Review Mechanism (TPRM) was an early result of the Uruguay Round**. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
 - The Uruguay Round was the 8th round of multilateral trade negotiations (MTN) conducted within the framework of the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT), spanning from 1986 to 1993 and embracing 123 countries as "contracting parties".

- It is the main transparency instrument of the WTO, affording opportunities for a process of collective evaluation of the trade policies and practices of individual members.

31. (a)

Explanation:

- Open Market Operations refers to **buying and selling of bonds issued by the Government in the open market**. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- **OMO is one of the quantitative tools that RBI** uses to smoothen the liquidity conditions through the year and minimise its impact on the interest rate and inflation rate levels. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
- Quantitative tools control the extent of money supply by changing the Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR), or bank rate or open market operations.
- Qualitative tools include persuasion by the Central bank in order to make commercial banks discourage or encourage lending which is done through moral suasion, margin requirement, etc.

32. (c)

Explanation:

A preferential trade agreement, is a trading bloc that gives **preferential access** to certain products from the participating countries.

This is done by reducing tariffs but not by abolishing them completely. A PTA can be established through a trade pact. It is the first stage of economic integration. **Hence, both statements 1 and 2 are correct.**

- A PTA can be established through a trade pact.
- The line between a PTA and a free trade area (FTA) may be blurred, as almost any PTA has a main goal of becoming a FTA in accordance with the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade.
- These tariff preferences have created numerous departures from the normal trade relations principle, namely that World Trade Organization (WTO) members should apply the same tariff to imports from other WTO members.
- With the recent multiplication of bilateral PTAs and the emergence of Mega-PTAs (wide regional trade agreements such as the Transatlantic Trade and Investment Partnership (TTIP) or Trans Pacific Partnership (TPP)), a global trade system exclusively managed within the framework of the WTO now seems unrealistic and the interactions between trade systems have to be taken into account.



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- The increased complexity of the international trade system generated by the multiplication of PTAs should be taken into account in the study of the choice of fora used by countries or regions to promote their trade relations and environmental agenda.

33. (c)

Explanation:

Gram UJALA Programme:

- An ambitious scheme offering the world's cheapest LED bulbs in rural areas at a mere Rs. 10. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- In its first phase launched from Arrah in Bihar, 15 million LED bulbs will be distributed across villages of 5 districts - Aarah (Bihar), Varanasi (Uttar Pradesh), Vijayawada (Andhra Pradesh), Nagpur (Maharashtra), and villages in western Gujarat.
- 7 watt and 12-watt LED bulbs with 3 years warranty will be given to rural consumers against submission of working Incandescent bulbs.
- The programme will be financed entirely through carbon credits and will be the first such programme in India. **Hence, both statements 2 and 3 are correct.**
- The revenue earned from carbon credits will contribute Rs. 60 per LED bulb piece, with the balance of Rs. 10 to be paid by the rural consumer.

34. (a)

Explanation:

- The Indian basket of crude oil defines the benchmark price at which crude oil is sourced by Indian refiners. **Hence, option (a) is correct.**
- The data is computed and published by the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC) under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.
- **Brent:** Brent is low-density crude oil with low sulphur content (sweet). It is extracted from the North Sea and comprises of Brent Blend, Forties Blend, Oseberg and Ekofisk crudes. Since it is low-density and low-sulphur oil, it is ideal for refining into diesel, petrol and other fuels.
- **West Texas Intermediate (WTI):** WTI is crude oil extracted from wells in the US. WTI is also light and sweet but since it is extracted in land-locked areas instead of sea, it becomes difficult from the transportation point of view. The WTI crude oil is sent via pipeline to Cushing, Oklahoma.

- **Dubai/Oman:** Dubai/Oman crude oil is of slightly lower quality, putting it in sour grade. It is a basket of crude oil from Dubai, Oman or Abu Dhabi. The composition of Dubai/Oman and Brent in the Indian basket of crude oil is decided on the processing capacity of oil companies. Dubai/Oman crude oil is popular in the Asian market.

35. (b)

Explanation:

The description is as below:

White label ATM	Brown Label ATM
When ATMs are owned and operated by non-bank entities but they are not doing 'outsourcing-contract' from a particular bank.	When banks outsourced the ATM operations to a third party.
The private company owns & operates the ATM machine, pays office rent. They negotiate with the landlord, electricity company, telecom company and so on.	Same
Sponsor bank provides the cash.	The bank (which has outsourced this work) provides cash for that ATM.
No. White label ATM doesn't have such logo. Not even of the sponsor bank.	ATM has logo of that bank (which has outsourced this work).
They've to compulsorily open a few ATMs in (tier 3 to tier 6) areas.	No such compulsion.
RBI directly involved because these white label Companies have to separately get license/permission from RBI to run business.	RBI not involved directly. These outsourcing companies have contractual obligation with their respective banks.

Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct while statement 2 is correct.

36. (c)

Explanation:

- The Government of India created the **Rural Infrastructure Development Fund (RIDF) in NABARD in 1995-96** by way of deposits from scheduled commercial banks operating within the country from the shortfall in their agricultural sector/priority sector/weaker section lending. The corpus of the fund has been extended on a year-to-year basis by GoI since then by provisions in the annual budget. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- The fund was established in view that many States have neglected investment in infrastructure for agriculture and many rural infrastructure projects were left pending for want of funds.



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- Such projects will assist states in completion of medium and minor irrigation, soil conservation, watershed management and other forms of rural infrastructure. Hence, statement 1 is correct.

37. (a)

Explanation:

Ken-Betwa Link Project:

- The Ken-Betwa Link Project (KBLP) is the River interlinking project that aims to transfer surplus water from the Ken river in MP to Betwa in UP to irrigate the drought-prone Bundelkhand region. Hence, statement 1 is correct.
- The region spread across the districts of two states mainly Jhansi, Banda, Lalitpur and Mahoba districts of UP and Tikamgarh, Panna and Chhatarpur districts of MP.
- The project involves building a 77-metre tall and 2-km wide Dhaudhan dam and a 230-km canal.

Ken and Betwa rivers:

- Ken and Betwa rivers originate in MP and are the tributaries of Yamuna.
- Rajghat, Paricha and Matatila dams are over the Betwa river. Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.
- Ken River passes through Panna tiger reserve. Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.

38. (a)

Explanation:

- An **Anti-Dumping Duty (ADD)** is a **customs duty** on imports providing a protection against the dumping of goods at prices substantially lower than the normal value whereas **Countervailing duty** is a **customs duty** on goods that have received government subsidies in the originating or exporting country. Hence, statement 1 is correct while statement 3 is NOT correct.
- The use of anti-dumping measures as an instrument of fair competition is permitted by the World Trade Organisation. Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.
- The NK Singh committee**, which was set up in 2016 to review the FRBM Act, recommended that the government must target a fiscal deficit of 3% of the GDP in the years up to March 31, 2020, subsequently cut it to 2.8% in 2020-21 and to 2.5% by 2023.
 - The Committee suggested using debt as the primary target for fiscal policy. A debt to GDP ratio of 60% should be targeted with a 40% limit for the centre and 20% limit for the states. The targeted debt to GDP ratio should be achieved by 2023.

39. (a)

Explanation:

Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) Act, 2003

- The FRBM Act 2003 aims to institutionalize financial discipline, reduce India's fiscal deficit, improve macroeconomic management and the overall management of the public funds by moving towards a balanced budget.

Objectives

- Reduction of fiscal deficit and revenue deficit;
- To achieve inter-generational equity in fiscal management by reducing the debt burden of the future generation;
- Achieving long-term macroeconomic stability;
- Better coordination between fiscal and monetary policy;
- Transparency in fiscal operations of the Government.

Major Provisions of the FRBM Act, 2003

- The FRBM rule set a target **reduction of fiscal deficit to 3% of the GDP by 2008-09**. This will be realized with an annual reduction target of 0.3% of GDP per year by the Central government.
- Revenue deficit has to be reduced by 0.5% of the GDP per year with complete elimination by 2008-09.
- Reduction of Public Debt
- The government has to take appropriate measures to reduce the fiscal deficit and revenue deficit so as to **eliminate the revenue deficit by 2008-09** and thereafter, a sizable revenue surplus has to be created.
- It mandated setting annual targets for the reduction of fiscal deficit and revenue deficit, contingent liabilities and total liabilities. Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.
- The **government shall end its borrowing from the RBI** except for temporary advances. Hence, statement 1 is correct.
- The RBI was supposed to not subscribe to the primary issues of the central government securities after 2006.
- The revenue deficit and fiscal deficit may exceed the targets specified in the rules only on grounds of national security, calamity and other exceptional grounds to be specified by the Central government.
- Amendments to FRBM Act:** Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management Act, 2003 was amended in 2012 that mandated the Central Government to lay before the Houses of Parliament, Macro-Economic Framework Statement, Medium Term Fiscal Policy Statement and Fiscal Policy Strategy Statement along with the Annual Financial Statement and Demands for Grants.



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 - The Committee suggested using debt as the primary target for fiscal policy. A debt to GDP ratio of 60% should be targeted with a 40% limit for the centre and 20% limit for the states. The targeted debt to GDP ratio should be achieved by 2023.

40. (b)**Explanation:**

- India was the biggest 'overperformer' in frontier technologies than the country's per capita Gross Domestic Products (GDP) would suggest, according to a recent country-readiness index of the **Technology And Innovation Report 2021**. Hence, statement 2 is correct.
- The report was released by the **United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD)**. Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.

About the Report:

- The report examines the likelihood of frontier technologies widening existing inequalities and creating new ones.
- It also addresses the national and international policies, instruments, and institutional reforms that are needed to create a more equal world of opportunity for all, leaving no one behind.
- Frontier technologies are defined as potentially disruptive technologies that can address large-scale challenges or opportunities. They include **artificial intelligence (AI), the internet of things, big data, blockchain, 5G, 3D printing, robotics, drones, gene editing, nanotechnology, and solar photovoltaic**.

United Nations Conference on Trade and Development

- The United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) was **established in 1964** to promote the development-friendly integration of developing countries into the world economy.
- UNCTAD is a permanent intergovernmental body headquartered in **Geneva in Switzerland**.

- Some of the reports published by it are:

- Trade and Development Report
- World Investment Report
- The Least Developed Countries Report
- Information and Economy Report
- Technology and Innovation Report
- Commodities and Development Report

41. (b)**Explanation:**

- The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs has released the final rankings of the Ease of Living Index (EoLI) 2020. Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.
- The Ease of Living Index (EoLI) is an assessment tool that evaluates the quality of life and the impact of various initiatives for urban development.
- It provides a comprehensive understanding of participating cities across India based on the quality of life, economic-ability of a city, and its sustainability and resilience.

EoLI 2020 ranking:

1. **Million+ category:** Bengaluru emerged as the top performer followed by Pune, Ahmedabad, Chennai, Surat, Navi Mumbai, Coimbatore, Vadodara, Indore, and Greater Mumbai.
2. **In the Less than Million category:** Shimla was ranked the highest in ease of living, followed by Bhubaneshwar, Silvassa, Kakinada, Salem, Vellore, Gandhinagar, Gurugram, Davangere, and Tiruchirappalli. Hence, statement 2 is correct.

42. (c)**Explanation:**

The Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change (MoEFCC) has declared an area of 1km around the Asola Bhatti Wildlife Sanctuary in Gurugram and Faridabad as an Eco-sensitive zone. Hence, statement 1 is correct.

- Activities such as commercial mining, setting up of industries, and establishment of major hydroelectric projects will be prohibited.

Why Eco-Sensitive zone tag to Asola Wildlife sanctuary?

- The Asola wildlife sanctuary has both floral and faunal diversity in the form of



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- Wide variety of trees, shrubs, herbs, and grasses.
- Large numbers of mammals, reptiles, amphibians, butterflies, and dragonflies.
- Sanctuary comprises Around 200 species of resident and migratory birds.
- Wildlife habitats inside the sanctuary act as water recharge zones for Delhi, Faridabad and Gurugram. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

43. (a)

Explanation:

The **World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO)** administers **WIPO Copyright Treaty** and **WIPO Performances and Phonogram Treaty**. They both are collectively known as **WIPO Internet Treaties**. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

The WIPO Internet Treaties lay down an international framework for preventing the unauthorised access to and use of creative works on the internet and other digital networks. It was concluded in 1996 and came into force in 2002.

Special 301 Report

- The Special 301 Report identifies trading partners that do **not adequately or effectively protect and enforce Intellectual Property (IP) rights** or otherwise **deny market access to U.S. innovators and creators that rely on protection of their IP rights**.
- The report is released **annually by the United States Trade Representative (USTR)**. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
- Trading partners that currently present the most significant concerns regarding IP rights **are placed on the Priority Watch List or Watch List**. USTR identified **33 countries for these lists in the Special 301 Report**:
 - Algeria, Argentina, Chile, China, India, Indonesia, Russia, Saudi Arabia, Ukraine and Venezuela are on the **Priority Watch List**.
 - Barbados, Bolivia, Brazil, Canada, Colombia, Dominican Republic, Ecuador, Egypt, Guatemala, Kuwait, Lebanon, Mexico, Pakistan, Paraguay, Peru, Romania, Thailand, Trinidad & Tobago, Turkey, Turkmenistan, the United Arab Emirates, Uzbekistan and Vietnam are on the **Watch List**.

44. (b)

Explanation:

Provisions of Borrowings under Indian Constitution

- **Borrowing by Centre and the States:** Chapter II in Part XII of the Constitution of India deals with borrowing. Article 292 covers borrowing by the Central Government, and Article 293 covers borrowing by States.
- **Empowering State Legislatures:** Article 293(1) provides State legislatures the power by law to enable or limit the State's executive powers of borrowing and giving guarantees.
- **Consent of the Centre:** Under clauses (3) and (4) of **Article 293, State Governments need to obtain the consent of the Centre** for raising fresh loans in case they are indebted to the latter, and such consent may be granted subject to conditions. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- **Entry 37 of the List 1 of the Seventh schedule** of the Constitution gives powers of raising foreign loans only to the Centre. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**

45. (b)

Explanation:

- **'Minor Forest Produce (MFP)'** means all non-timber forest produce of plant origin and will include bamboo, canes, fodder, **leaves, gums, waxes, dyes, resins** and many forms of food including nuts, wild fruits, Honey, Lac, Tusser etc. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- MFP is gathered by the people living in forested areas. Some amount of primary processing, such as drying of leaves, deseeding, etc. are taken up by gatherers. These are then sold to private traders or State Government agencies. State Governments exercise control over the use and trade of MFP through various Acts and regulations.
- **The Ministry of Tribal Affairs, Govt of India** is the Nodal Ministry for implementation and monitoring of the scheme. **The Ministry of Tribal Affairs announces Minimum Support Price (MSP) for the selected MFPs** with the technical support from **TRIFED**. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- The basic component of the scheme includes declaration of MSP for notified MFPs by the Central Government based on the recommendation of the Pricing Cell set up within TRIFED.



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46. (c)

Explanation:

**Nordic Region**

The Nordic Region consists of Denmark, Norway, Sweden, Finland and Iceland, as well as the Faroe Islands, Greenland and Åland. **Hence, option (c) is correct.**

47. (d)

Explanation:

- Core inflation is an inflation measure which **excludes** transitory or temporary price volatility as in the case of some commodities such as food items, energy products etc. It reflects the inflation trend in an economy. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- Headline inflation is a measure of total inflation within an economy **including** commodities such as food and energy prices, which tend to be much more **volatile** and prone to inflationary spikes. **Hence statement 2 is NOT correct.**
- Headline inflation may not present an accurate picture of an economy's inflationary trend since sector-specific inflationary spikes are unlikely to persist.

48. (b)

Explanation:

About Exercise AsterX:

- France has begun its first military exercise to test its ability to defend its satellites.

- The exercise has been named AsterX in reference to the first French satellite, which was put into orbit in 1965.
- **Purpose:** During the exercise, the French Military aims to monitor a potentially dangerous space object. It will also analyze threats to its own satellite from another foreign power possessing a considerable space force. **Hence, option (b) is correct.**
- **Participation:** The new US Space Force and German space agencies are also taking part in this exercise along with France.

49. (c)

Explanation:

- The European Free Trade Association (EFTA) is an intergovernmental organisation of **Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland**. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- It was set up in 1960 by its then seven Member States for the promotion of free trade and economic integration between its members.
- India has bilateral trade arrangements with all major regional groupings. In Europe, it is a part of European Free Trade Association (EFTA).
- None of the EFTA member States are member of European Union (EU). **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

50. (b)

Explanation:

Better than Cash Alliance:

- Based at the **United Nations**, the Better-Than-Cash-Alliance is a partnership of governments, companies, and international organizations that accelerates the transition from cash to responsible digital payments.
- The Alliance has 75 members which are committed to digitizing payments.
- The Alliance Secretariat works with members on their journey to digitize payments by:
 - Providing advisory services based on their priorities.
 - Sharing action-oriented research and fostering peer learning on responsible practices.
 - Conducting advocacy at the national, regional, and global levels.
- It was created in **2012**. It was launched by the United Nations Capital Development Fund, the United States Agency for International Development, the Bill &

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Melinda Gates Foundation, Citigroup, the Ford Foundation, the Omidyar Network, and Visa Inc. **Hence, option (b) is correct.**

51. (a)

Explanation:

- The Union Budget 2021 has announced the privatisation of two public sector banks and one general insurance company in the upcoming fiscal 2021-22.
- Many committees had proposed bringing down the government stake in public banks below 51%:

Narasimham Committee, 1998

- The merger of major banks which will have a 'multiplier effect' on the industry.
- Improve the strength of the Indian banking system the committee recommended to raise capital adequacy norms.
- Review of functions of boards to adopt a professional corporate strategy to check the imbalance between government control over the banks in the form of management and ownership, and bank autonomy.

PJ Nayak Committee, 2014

- Conversion of PSBs into Companies as per the Companies Act.
- Formation of a Bank Investment Company (BIC) under the Companies Act and transfer of shares by the central government in PSBs to the BIC.
- BIC should be given the controlling power of boards of PSBs.
- Proportionate voting rights to all shareholders and reduction of government shareholding to 40%.
- Abhijit Sen Committee (2002) is related to the **Long Term Food Policy of India**.
- The Abhijit Sen committee (2007) was formed to study the **impact, if any, of futures trading on agricultural commodity prices (not banking reforms)**.

Hence, option (a) is correct.

52. (b)

Explanation:

Electronic Clearing Services (ECS)

- Electronic Clearing Services (ECS) is an electronic mode of payment/receipt for transactions that are repetitive and periodic in nature. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

ECS is used by institutions for making bulk payment of amounts towards distribution of dividend, interest, salary, pension, etc., or for bulk collection of amounts towards telephone / electricity / water dues, cess / tax collections, loan instalment repayments, periodic investments in mutual funds, insurance premium etc.

ECS includes transactions processed under National Automated Clearing House (NACH) operated by National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI).

- **Contactless payment** is a secure method for consumers to purchase products or services using a debit, credit, or smartcard—also known as a chip card—by using RFID technology or near-field communication (NFC). RBI has placed the limit of Rs.5000/- per transaction across all categories of merchants in the country where such contactless payments can take place. **Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.**

National Payments Corporation of India

- National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), an umbrella organisation for operating retail payments and settlement systems in India, is an initiative of **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** and Indian Banks' Association (IBA) under the provisions of the **Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007**.
- It is a **"Not for Profit"** Company under the provisions of **Section 25 of Companies Act 1956 (now Section 8 of Companies Act 2013)**, with an intention to provide infrastructure to the entire Banking system in India for **physical** as well as **electronic** payment and settlement systems.

Various NPCI Operated Systems

- **Bharat Interface for Money-Unified Payments Interface (BHIM-UPI):**
 - It is an initiative to enable fast, secure, reliable cashless payments through the mobile phone. BHIM is based on **Unified Payment Interface (UPI)** to facilitate e-payments directly through banks. It is an **app**.
 - This is a system that **powers multiple bank accounts into a single mobile application** (of any participating bank), merging several banking features, seamless fund routing & merchant payments into one hood.
- **Aadhaar enabled Payment System (AePS):**
 - AePS allows people to carry out financial transactions on a Micro-ATM by furnishing just their Aadhaar number and verifying it with the help of their fingerprint/iris scan.



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- **National Electronic Toll Collection (NETC):**
 - It helps in electronic toll collection at toll plazas using FASTag.
 - **FASTag** is a device that employs **Radio Frequency Identification (RFID)** technology for making toll payments directly while the vehicle is in motion.
- **National Automated Clearing House (NACH):**
 - It is a service offered by NPCI to banks which aims at facilitating interbank high volume, low value debit/credit transactions, which are repetitive and electronic in nature. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- **Immediate Payment Service (IMPS):**
 - It offers an **instant 24×7 interbank electronic fund transfer service** through mobile phones.
 - IMPS is an emphatic tool to transfer money instantly within banks across India through mobile, internet and ATM.
- **Bharat Bill Payment System (BBPS):**
 - Bharat Bill Payment System is a tiered structure for operating a unified bill payment system.
 - NPCI functions as the authorised **Bharat Bill Payment Central Unit (BBPCU)**, which is responsible for setting business standards, rules and procedures for technical and business requirements for all the participants.
 - Under **BBPS, the Bharat Bill Payment Operating Units (BBPOUs)** function as entities facilitating collection of repetitive payments for **everyday utility services**, such as, electricity, water, gas, telephone and Direct-to-Home (DTH).
- **RuPay:**
 - RuPay is the **first-of-its-kind domestic card payment network of India**, with wide acceptance at ATMs, POS devices and e-commerce websites across India. It is a highly secure network that **protects against anti-phishing.**

53. (d)

Explanation:

- Government launched the 'Pradhan Mantri Vaya Vandana Yojana' (PMVVY) scheme to protect elderly persons aged 60 years and above against a future fall in their interest income due to the uncertain market conditions. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

- Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana (PMJJBY) and Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY) were launched in **9th May, 2015**. These schemes are offered/administered through **both public and private sector insurance companies**, in tie up with scheduled commercial banks, regional rural banks and cooperative banks. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PMJAY) is a **centrally sponsored scheme**. PMJAY provides health insurance coverage of upto **₹5 lakh per family** per year for secondary and tertiary hospitalization to 10.74 crore poor and vulnerable families (approximately 50 crore beneficiaries). **Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

54. (a)

Explanation:

- Hirakud Dam is built across the Mahanadi River, close to Sambalpur city in Odisha in India.
- With successful irrigation provided by the dam, Sambalpur is called the rice bowl of Odisha.
- Major Tributaries of Mahanadi are:
 - Jonk
 - Hasdeo
 - Ong
 - Mand
 - Ib
 - Tel
 - Seonath

Hence, option (a) is correct.

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**55. (d)****Explanation:**

- The **Food Waste Index Report** aims at supporting the goals of **SDG 12.3**.
- It is published by United Nations Environment Program (UNEP). **Hence, option (d) is correct.**

56. (d)**Explanation:**

- The government has set a target of doubling of farmers' income by the year 2022. For the said purpose, the Government constituted an Inter-Ministerial Committee to examine issues relating to Doubling of Farmers' income.
- The committee has identified seven sources of income growth for farmers:
 - Improvement in crop productivity
 - Improvement in livestock productivity
 - Resource use efficiency or savings in the cost of production
 - Increase in the cropping intensity
 - Diversification towards high-value crops
 - Improvement in real prices received by farmers
 - Shift from farm to non-farm occupations **Hence, option (d) is correct.**

57. (c)**Explanation:**

- Internationally GI are covered as a component of Intellectual Property Rights (IPRs) under the Paris Convention for the Protection of Industrial Property.
- GI is also governed by the **World Trade Organisation's (WTO's) Agreement on Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPS)**. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- India, as a member of the World Trade Organization (WTO), enacted the **Geographical Indications of Goods (Registration & Protection) Act, 1999** which came into force with effect from 2003.
- The registration of a geographical indication is valid for a period of **10 years**. It can be renewed from time to time for a further period of 10 years each. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

58. (d)**Explanation:****Hence, option (b) is correct.****59. (d)****Explanation:****National Food Security Act 2013:**

- The National Food Security Act, 2013 (NFSA) provides a legal basis for the public distribution system (PDS). **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The NFSA made access to the PDS a right, entitling every person belonging to a "priority household" to receive 5 kg of foodgrains per month at a subsidised price not exceeding Rs 2/kg for wheat and Rs 3/kg for rice.
- Priority households were further defined to cover up to 75% of the country's rural population and 50% in urban areas.

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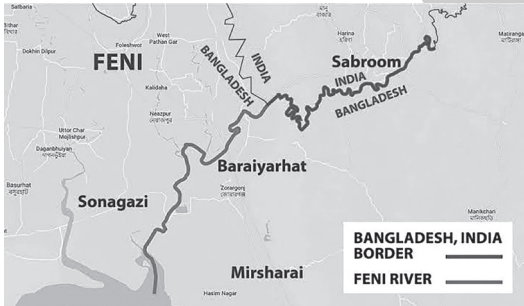


- CACP is a statutory body set up through an Act of Parliament. "CACP is an attached office of the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, Government of India". It recommends MSPs. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- Sugarcane pricing is governed by the Sugarcane (Control) Order, 1966 issued under the Essential Commodities Act. That order, in turn, provides for the fixation of a 'fair and remunerative price' (FRP) for cane during every sugar year. **Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

60. (c)

Explanation:

- Indian Prime Minister had inaugurated the 'Maitri Setu' between India and Bangladesh.
- **Constructed by:** National Highways and Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- The bridge 'Maitri Setu' has been built over the Feni river. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The river flows between Tripura and Bangladesh.
- The bridge joins Sabroom (in Tripura) with Ramgarh (in Bangladesh).
- With this bridge, Tripura is set to become the 'Gateway of North East' with access to Chittagong Port of Bangladesh, which is 80 km from Sabroom.



61. (c)

Explanation:

All India Survey on Higher Education

- The Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education conducts annual web-based All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) since 2010-11.
- The survey covers all the Institutions in the country engaged in imparting higher education. Data is being collected on several parameters such as teachers, student enrolment, programmes, examination results, education finance, infrastructure. **Hence, pair 1 is correctly matched.**

School Education Quality Index

- The School Education Quality Index (SEQI) was developed by **NITI Aayog**. The aim is to evaluate the performance of States and Union Territories (UTs) in the school education sector. **Hence, pair 2 is NOT correctly matched.**
- The index aims to bring an outcome based focus to education policy by providing States and UTs with a platform to identify their strengths and weaknesses and undertake requisite course corrections or policy interventions.

Performance Grading Index (PGI)

- The PGI is a tool to provide insights on the status of the school education in states and UTs including key levers that drive their performance and critical areas of improvement.
- The index is released by the Department of School Education and Literacy under the Ministry of Education. **Hence, pair 3 is NOT correctly matched**

Programme for International Students Assessment (PISA)

- PISA is an international survey held every three years, coordinated by the **Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD)**. **Hence, pair 4 is correctly matched.**
- First conducted in 2000, the major domain of study rotates between reading, mathematics, and science in each cycle.
- It is a competency-based test designed to assess the ability of the 15-year-old candidates that measures their reading, mathematics, and science literacy every three years to apply their knowledge to real-life situations.

62. (b)

Explanation:

- The Indian economy has emerged out of technical recession as it grew at 0.4% in the third (October-December) quarter of 2020-21 with improvement in manufacturing, construction and agriculture.
- A **technical recession** is when a country faces a continuous decline for two consecutive quarters in the GDP. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- The growth rate in terms of **Gross Value Added (GVA)** — which is the **Gross Domestic Product (GDP) minus net product taxes**. (It reflects growth in supply) — is seen contracting 6.5% in 2020-21 as against earlier estimates of 7.2% and 3.9% in the previous year. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**



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**63. (a)****Explanation:**

- The **Monetary Policy Committee (MPC)** is a statutory and institutionalized framework under the **Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934**, for maintaining price stability, while keeping in mind the objective of growth. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The **Governor of RBI** is ex-officio Chairman of the committee. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
- The **MPC determines the policy interest rate (repo rate)** required to achieve the inflation target (4%).
 - It is the **Central Government** of India that **determines the Inflation Target**. **Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.**
- An RBI-appointed committee led by the then deputy governor Urjit Patel in 2014 recommended the establishment of the Monetary Policy Committee.

64. (b)**Explanation:****Permanent Indus Commission:**

- It is a bilateral commission of officials from India and Pakistan, created to implement and manage the goals of the Indus Waters Treaty, 1960.
- The Commission, according to the treaty, shall meet regularly at least once a year, alternately in India and Pakistan.
- **The functions of the Commission include:**
 - To study and report to the two Governments on any problem relating to the development of the waters of the rivers. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
 - To solve disputes arising over water sharing. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
 - To arrange technical visits to projects' sites and critical river head works.
 - To undertake, once in every five years, a general tour of inspection of the Rivers for ascertaining the facts. **Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.**
 - To take necessary steps for the implementation of the provisions of the treaty.

65. (b)**Explanation:**

When the relationship between per capita consumption and per capita national income shows a very high elasticity of consumption, it implies that the growth rate of consumption per capita is almost the same as that of per capita income. **Hence, option (b) is correct.**

66. (c)**Explanation:****'One Nation, One Ration Card' system**

Under the National Food Security Act, 2013, about 81 crore persons are entitled to buy subsidized foodgrain — rice at Rs 3/kg, wheat at Rs 2/kg, and coarse grains at Rs 1/kg — from their designated Fair Price Shops (FPS) of the Targeted Public Distribution System (TPDS).

- Under the 'One Nation, One Ration Card' system, the beneficiary will be able to buy subsidised foodgrains from any FPS across the country. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The new system, based on a technological solution, will identify a beneficiary through biometric authentication on electronic Point of Sale (ePoS) devices installed at the FPSs, and enable that person to purchase the quantity of foodgrains to which she is entitled under the NFSA.

'Integrated Management of PDS' (IM-PDS)

A new Central Sector Scheme has been implemented for establishing Public Distribution System Network (PDSN) to implement national level portability, central data repository and central monitoring system of PDS operations. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

67. (c)**Explanation:**

- The Sovereign Gold Bond Scheme seeks to encourage people to buy gold bonds instead of actual gold.
- The **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** issues these bonds on behalf of the Central Government. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The gold bonds will be denominated in multiples of gram (s) of gold with a basic unit of one gram while the minimum investment limit is two grams.
- The maximum subscription is 500 grams per person per fiscal (April-March) and for joint holders, the limit will be applied on the first holder.
- The **gold bonds will be sold only to resident Indian entities** including individuals, Hindu undivided families, trusts, universities, and charitable institutions. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- The bond tenure is eight years with exit option beginning the fifth year onwards. They will also be tradable.
- These bonds can also be used as collateral for loans.



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**68. (b)****Explanation:**

- The **current account records exports and imports in goods and services and transfer payments. Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
 - It represents a country's transactions with the rest of the world and, like the capital account, is a component of a country's Balance of Payments (BOP).
- There is a deficit in Current Account if the value of the goods and services imported exceeds the value of those exported.
- **Current Account Deficit could be reduced by boosting exports and curbing non-essential imports** such as gold, mobiles, and electronics. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

69. (d)**Explanation:****Gandhi Peace Prize:**

- The annual award was instituted by the Government of India in 1995 during the commemoration of the 125th birth anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi for those involved in social, economic and political transformation through non-violence.
- The award carries an amount of Rs. 1 crore, a citation in a scroll, a plaque as well as an exquisite traditional handicraft/handloom item.
- The prize can be given to individuals, associations, institutions or organizations.
- The jury chaired by the **Prime Minister** and other members is the **Chief Justice of India**, the leader of the single largest **Opposition party in the Lok Sabha**, **Lok Sabha Speaker** and **founder of Sulabh International** are present as two eminent persons. **Hence, option (d) is correct.**

70. (b)**Explanation:**

- UJALA Scheme, launched in 2015, aimed at distribution of affordable LEDs to the customers. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- Saubhagya Scheme is aimed at providing free electricity connections to the poor families. **Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.**

- Ministry of Power's **Ujwal DISCOM Assurance Yojna or UDAY** provides for the financial turnaround and revival of Power Distribution companies (DISCOMs), and importantly also ensures a sustainable permanent solution to the problem.
- UDAY assures the rise of vibrant and efficient DISCOMs through a permanent resolution of past as well as potential future issues of the sector. It empowers DISCOMs with the opportunity to break even in the next 2-3 years.
- **This is through four initiatives:**
 - Improving operational efficiencies of DISCOMs.
 - Reduction of cost of generation of power. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
 - Reduction in interest cost of DISCOMs.
 - Enforcing financial discipline on DISCOMs through alignment with State finances. **Hence, statement 4 is correct.**

71. (b)**Explanation:**

- Infrastructure Investment Trust (InvIT) is a collective investment scheme similar to a mutual fund, which enables **direct investment of money from individual and institutional investors** in infrastructure projects to earn a small portion of the income as return. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
 - InvITs can be treated as the modified version of REITs (real estate investment trusts) designed to suit the specific circumstances of the infrastructure sector.
 - It is created to hold income-generating and operational infrastructure assets such as roads, power transmission lines, gas pipelines, etc.
 - These assets have long-term contracts with strong counterparties that provide a steady cash flow over the long term – typically 15-20 years.
- The InvITs are **regulated by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)** (Infrastructure Investment Trusts) Regulations, 2014. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

72. (a)**Explanation:**

- Different from the usual taxes and duties like excise and personal income tax, a **Cess is imposed as an additional tax** besides the existing tax (tax on tax) with a purpose of **raising funds for a specific task. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

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- The Union government is empowered to raise revenue through a gamut of levies, including taxes (both direct and indirect), surcharges, fees and cess.
 - A cess, generally paid by everyday public, is added to their basic tax liability paid as part of total tax paid.
 - **Article 270** of the Constitution allows cess to be excluded from the purview of the divisible pool of taxes that the Union government must share with the States. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
 - ◆ Article 250 mentions the power of Parliament to legislate with respect to any matter in the State List in case of emergency.
- Cess should be kept as a separate fund after allocating to Consolidated Fund of India and can be spent only for a specific purpose.
- A cess is meant to raise revenue and is therefore temporary in nature.
 - A particular cess continues to be levied till the time the government collects enough funds for the purpose that it was introduced for.

73. (b)

Explanation:

- **Foreign exchange reserves** are assets held on reserve by a central bank in foreign currencies, which can include bonds, treasury bills and other government securities.
- **India's Forex Reserve include:**
 - Foreign Currency Assets
 - Gold reserves
 - Special Drawing Rights
 - Reserve position with the IMF.**Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- Foreign Currency Assets (FCA) are assets that are valued based on a currency other than the country's own currency.
 - FCA is the largest component of the forex reserve. It is **expressed in dollar terms. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
 - The FCAs also include the effect of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units like the euro, pound and yen held in the foreign exchange reserves.

74. (c)

Explanation:**About Similipal Biosphere Reserve:**

- Similipal derives its name from the 'Simul' (silk cotton) tree.

- It was formally designated a **Tiger Reserve** in 1956 and brought under **Project Tiger in the year 1973.**
- It was declared a Biosphere Reserve by the Government of India in June **1994.**
- It has been part of the **UNESCO World Network of Biosphere Reserve since 2009. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- It is part of the **Similipal-Kuldiha-Hadgarh Elephant Reserve** popularly known as **Mayurbhanj Elephant Reserve**, which includes 3 protected areas i.e. Similipal Tiger Reserve, Hadagarh Wildlife sanctuary, and Kuldiha wildlife sanctuary. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Location:

- It is situated in the northern part of Odisha's Mayurbhanj district. Geographically, it lies in the eastern end of the eastern ghat.
 - **Coverage:** The biosphere spread over 4,374 sq. km. has 845 sq. km. of core forest (tiger reserve), 2,129 sq km buffer area, and 1,400 sq km of transition space.
 - **Vegetation:** Similipal has 1,076 flowering species and 96 species of orchids. It boasts of having tropical semi-evergreen forests, tropical moist deciduous forests, dry deciduous hill forests, high-level sal forests, and sprawling meadows.
 - **Tribes:** Two tribes, the Erenga Kharias and the Mankirdias, inhabit the reserve's forests and practise traditional agricultural activities (the collection of seeds and timber).

75. (b)

Explanation:**National Cyber Security Strategy 2020:**

- **Aim:** To improve cyber awareness and cybersecurity through more stringent audits.
- This National Cyber Security Strategy 2020 is an upgraded version of Cyber Security Policy 2013. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- **Present Government Initiatives:**
 - Cyber Surakshit Bharat Initiative.
 - Cyber Swachhta Kendra.
 - Online cybercrime reporting portal.
 - Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C).
 - National Critical Information Infrastructure Protection Centre (NCIIPC).
 - Information Technology Act, 2000.
 - National Cyber Policy, 2013.

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**About C- DAC:**

- Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC) is the premier R&D organization of the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) for carrying out R&D in IT, Electronics and associated areas.
- The setting up of C-DAC in 1988 itself was to build Supercomputers in the context of denial of import of Supercomputers by the USA. Since then C-DAC has been undertaking the building of multiple generations of Supercomputers starting from PARAM with 1 GF in 1988. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

76. (b)**Explanation:**

- Recently, the government accepted the 15th Finance Commission's recommendation to maintain the States' share in the divisible pool of taxes to 41% for the five-year period starting 2021-22.
- **Vertical Devolution (Devolution of Taxes of the Union to States):**
 - It has recommended maintaining the vertical devolution at 41% - the same as in its interim report for 2020-21. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
 - It is at the same level of 42% of the divisible pool as recommended by the 14th Finance Commission.
 - It has made the required adjustment of about 1% due to the changed status of the erstwhile State of Jammu and Kashmir into the new Union Territories of Ladakh and Jammu and Kashmir.
- **Horizontal Devolution (Allocation Between the States):**
 - For horizontal devolution, it has suggested 12.5% weightage to demographic performance, 45% to income distance, 15% each to population and area, 10% to forest and ecology and 2.5% to tax and fiscal efforts. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

77. (d)**Explanation:****Priority Sector Lending (PSL)**

- The RBI mandates banks to lend a certain portion of their funds to specified sectors, like agriculture, Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), export credit, education, housing, social infrastructure, renewable energy among others.

- All **scheduled commercial banks and foreign banks** (with a sizable presence in India) are mandated to set aside 40% of their Adjusted Net Bank Credit (ANBC) for lending to these sectors. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- Regional rural banks, co-operative banks and small finance banks have to allocate 75% of ANBC to PSL. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
- The idea behind this is to ensure that adequate institutional credit reaches some of the vulnerable sectors of the economy, which otherwise may not be attractive for banks from the profitability point of view.

78. (d)**Explanation:**

- India faced a major blow to its economy when, in 1991, balance of payment crisis loomed large.
- There were several different reasons which are as follows:
 - Due to the **Gulf War (1990-91)**, the **higher oil prices** were quickly depleting India's foreign reserves.
 - Sharp **decline in the private remittances** from the overseas Indian workers in the wake of the Gulf War, especially from the Gulf region.
 - A **loss of confidence in the government**
 - India's post-independence development strategy was both **inward-looking and highly interventionist**.
 - **Complex industrial licensing** requirements **Hence, option (d) is correct.**

79. (c)**Explanation:****QUASAR:**

- A quasar known as a quasi-stellar object is an extremely luminous active galactic nucleus (AGN), in which a supermassive black hole with mass ranging from millions to billions of times the mass of the Sun is surrounded by a gaseous accretion disk. **Hence, statements 1 and 2 are correct.**
- As gas in the disk falls towards the black hole, energy is released in the form of electromagnetic radiation, which can be observed across the electromagnetic spectrum.
- The power radiated by quasars is enormous; the most powerful quasars have luminosities thousands of times greater than a galaxy such as the Milky Way.
- Most active galaxies have a supermassive black hole at the centre which sucks in surrounding objects.

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- Quasars are formed by the energy emitted by materials spiralling around a black hole right before being sucked into it.

80. (d)

Explanation:

Rashtriya Uchchatar Shiksha Abhiyan(RUSA):

- Rashtriya Uchchatar Shiksha Abhiyan is a **Centrally Sponsored Scheme** launched in **2013**. Hence, **statement 1 is NOT correct**.
- It aimed to increase enrolment in higher education by 30%. Hence, **statement 2 is NOT correct**.
- The RUSA, unlike other schemes, is not imposed on State governments in a one-size-fits-all manner.
- Under RUSA, states and institutions have to give an undertaking expressing their willingness to the idea of reform.
- They should also agree to meet the States' share of the cost.
- Accordingly, preparatory grants will be released to States to have the required systems, processes, and technical support in place.
- The scheme is largely based on the conditional release of funds.
- It is linked to reforms in the key areas of governance, learning-teaching outcomes, reaching out to the unreached, and infrastructure support.

81. (a)

Explanation:

- At times it may happen that a taxpayer, being a company, may have generated income during the year, but by taking the advantage of various provisions of Income-tax Law (like exemptions, deductions, depreciation, etc.), it may have reduced its tax liability or may not have paid any tax at all.
- Due to an increase in the number of zero tax paying companies, Minimum Alternate Tax (MAT)** was introduced by the **Finance Act, 1987** with effect from assessment year 1988-89. Later on, it was withdrawn by the Finance Act, 1990 and then reintroduced by the Finance Act, 1996. Hence, **statement 1 is correct**.
- MAT is calculated at 15% on the book profit (the profit shown in the profit and loss account) or at the usual corporate rates, and whichever is higher is payable as tax.
- All companies in India, whether domestic or foreign**, fall under this provision. MAT was later extended to cover non-corporate entities as well. Hence, **statement 2 is NOT correct**.

- MAT is an important tool with which tax avoidance can be prevented.

82. (c)

Explanation:

- Currency depreciation** is a fall in the value of a currency in a floating exchange rate system.
 - In a floating exchange rate system, market forces (based on demand and supply of a currency) determine the value of a currency.
- Currency depreciation **increases a country's export activity as its products and services become cheaper to buy**. Hence, **statement 1 is correct**.
- Foreign tourists are the gainers of currency depreciation, as travel to India gets **cheaper (not costly)**. Hence, **statement 2 is NOT correct**.
- Impact of Depreciating Rupee:**
 - Losers:**
 - People Importing from outside.
 - People seeking foreign education.
 - People travelling abroad.
 - People investing abroad.
 - People seeking medical treatment abroad etc.
 - Gainers:**
 - People exporting from India.
 - People receiving remittances from abroad or Non Resident Indian (NRI). Hence, **statement 3 is correct**.

83. (b)

Explanation:

- The term "**Corporate Social Responsibility**" in general can be referred to as a corporate initiative to assess and take responsibility for the company's effects on the environment and impact on social welfare.
- In India, **the concept of CSR is governed by clause 135 of the Companies Act, 2013**. Hence, **statement 1 is NOT correct**.
 - India is the first country in the world to mandate CSR spending along with a framework to identify potential CSR activities.
- The CSR provisions within the Act is **applicable to companies with an annual turnover of 1,000 crore and more, or a net worth of Rs. 500 crore and more, or a net profit of Rs. 5 crore and more**. Hence, **statement 2 is correct**.



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**84. (d)****Explanation:****The Policy of Neutrality:**

- It is a foreign policy position wherein a state intends to remain neutral in future wars.
- A permanently neutral power is a sovereign state which is bound by an international treaty, or by its declaration, to be neutral towards the belligerents of all future wars. **Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- An example of a permanently neutral power is Switzerland. Other being Ireland, Austria, etc. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
- International Day of Neutrality is a United Nations recognized day held on 12th December each year to raise public awareness of the value of neutrality in international relations.
- In 1783, Switzerland was acknowledged as a neutral state in the Treaty of Paris.
- National policies of neutrality are aimed at promoting the use of preventive diplomacy, which is a core function of the United Nations.
- The term “Preventive diplomacy” refers to diplomatic action taken to prevent disputes from escalating into conflicts and to limit the spread of conflicts when they occur.

85. (c)**Explanation:**

- In the Budget 2021-22, **Asset Reconstruction Companies (ARC)** have been proposed to be set up by state-owned and private sector banks, and **there will be no equity contribution from the government. Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.**
- It is a specialized financial institution that **buys the Non Performing Assets (NPAs) from banks and financial institutions** so that they can clean up their balance sheets. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 provides the legal basis for the setting up of ARCs in India. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

86. (a)**Explanation:**

- The **National Electronic Fund Transfer (NEFT)** system is the **Centralised Payment Systems (CPSs) of the RBI.**

- It is an **electronic fund transfer system in which the transactions received up to a particular time are processed in batches.**

- There is no limit imposed by RBI in fund transfer through NEFT.

Hence, option (a) is correct.

- The **Real Time Gross Settlement (RTGS)** System is the Centralised Payment Systems (CPSs) of the RBI.
 - It enables **real-time transfer** of funds to a beneficiary's account and is primarily meant for large-value transactions.
 - Real time means the processing of instructions at the time they are received and gross settlement implies that settlement of funds transfer instructions occurs individually.
- The Cheque Truncation System (CTS) and the Express Cheque Clearing System (ECCS) are the decentralised payment systems of RBI.

87. (a)**Explanation:****Purple Revolution (Under Aroma Mission):**

- First-time farmers in Jammu had their incomes quadrupled after shifting from **maize to lavender** cultivation which is **being called the purple revolution.** They were given free lavender saplings and those who have cultivated lavender before were charged Rs. 5-6 per sapling.
- **Aim:** To support domestic aromatic crop-based agro-economy by moving from imported aromatic oils to homegrown varieties.
- The main product is Lavender oil which sells for at least Rs. 10,000 per litre.
- Lavender water, which separates from lavender oil, is used to make incense sticks.
- Hydrosol, which is formed after distillation from the flowers, is used to make soaps and room fresheners.
- Apart from being in sync with government policy of doubling farm incomes by 2022, lavender cultivation also employed the district's women farmers thus giving impetus to inclusive growth.

Hence, option (a) is correct.**88. (a)****Explanation:**

- Negative rate policy – once considered only for economies with chronically low inflation such as Europe and Japan – is becoming a more attractive option for some other

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central banks to counter unwelcome rises in their currencies. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**

Why have some central banks adopted negative rates?

- To battle the global financial crisis triggered by the collapse of Lehman Brothers in 2008, many central banks cut interest rates near zero. A decade later, interest rates remain low in most countries due to subdued economic growth.
- With little room to cut rates further, some major central banks have resorted to unconventional policy measures, including a negative rate policy.
- The Euro area, Switzerland, Denmark, Sweden and Japan have allowed rates to fall slightly below zero.

How does it work?

- Under a negative rate policy, financial institutions are required to pay interest for parking excess reserves with the central bank. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- That way, central banks penalise financial institutions for holding on to cash in hope of prompting them to boost lending.

89. (a)

Explanation:

Pench Wildlife Sanctuary :

- **About:**
 - It is located in **Nagpur District of Maharashtra** and is named after the pristine **Pench River**.
 - ◆ The Pench river flows right through the middle of the park.
 - ◆ It descends from north to south, thereby dividing the reserve into equal eastern and western parts.
 - Pench Tiger Reserve is the joint pride of both **Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra**.
 - ◆ The Reserve is located in the southern reaches of the Satpura hills in the Seoni and Chhindwara districts in Madhya Pradesh and continues in Nagpur district in Maharashtra as a separate Sanctuary.
 - It is among the sites notified as **Important Bird Areas (IBA) of India**.
 - ◆ The IBA is a programme of Birdlife International which aims to identify, monitor and protect a global network of IBAs for conservation of the world's birds and associated diversity.

Important Tiger Reserves in India:



90. (a)

Explanation:

Recently the Prime Minister has flagged off a commemorative 'Dandi March' (on 12th March) to launch the celebrations of the 75th year of Independence - 'Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav'.

● About the 2021 Dandi March:

- The padayatra is being undertaken by 81 marchers from **Sabarmati Ashram in Ahmedabad to Dandi in Navsari**, a journey of 386 km. The march will end after 25 days, on 5th April 2021.
- Descendants of those who walked the Salt March (in 1930) will be honoured.

● About the 1930 Dandi March:

- The Dandi March, also known as the Salt March and the Dandi Satyagraha was an act of non-violent civil disobedience led by Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi.
- The march lasted from **12th March 1930 to 6th April 1930** as a direct action campaign of tax resistance and nonviolent protest against the British salt monopoly.
- On 12th March, Gandhiji set out from Sabarmati with 78 followers on a 241-mile march to the coastal town of Dandi on the Arabian Sea. There, Gandhi and his supporters were to defy British policy by making salt from seawater.



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- At Dandi, thousands more followed his lead, and in the coastal cities of Bombay and Karachi, Indian nationalists led crowds of citizens in making salt.
- Civil disobedience broke out all across India, soon involving millions of Indians, and British authorities arrested more than 60,000 people. Gandhiji himself was arrested on 5th May, but the satyagraha continued without him. **Hence, option (a) is correct.**

91. (a)**Explanation:****The 15th Finance Commission has considered:**

Criteria	14 th FC 2015-20	15 th FC 2020-21
Income Distance	50.0	45.0
Population (1971)	17.5	—
Population (2011)	10.0	15.0
Area	15.0	15.0
Forest Cover	7.5	—
Forest and Ecology	—	10.0
Demographic Performance	—	12.5
Tax Effort	—	2.5
Total	100	100

To arrive at the states' share in the divisible pool of taxes.

Hence, option (a) is correct.

- In order to reward population control efforts by states, the Commission developed a criterion for demographic effort — which is essentially the ratio of the state's population in 1971 to its fertility rate in 2011 — with a weight of 12.5%.

Key recommendations:

- The Commission has reduced the vertical devolution — the share of tax revenues that the Centre shares with the states — from 42% to 41%. The 1% decrease is to provide for the newly formed union territories of Jammu and Kashmir, and Ladakh from the resources of the central government.
- The Commission has said that it intends to set up an expert group to initiate a non-lapsable fund for defence expenditure.

Extra Info:

- The population parameter used by the Commission has been criticised by the governments of the southern states. The previous Finance Commission used both the 1971 and the 2011 populations to calculate the states' shares, giving greater weight to the 1971 population (17.5%) as compared to the 2011 population (10%).
- The use of 2011 population figures has resulted in states with larger populations like UP and Bihar getting larger shares, while smaller states with lower fertility rates have lost out. The combined population of Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Jharkhand is 47.8 crore.

92. (c)**Explanation:****Aravalli Range:**

- The Aravalli Range is one of the most popular mountain ranges and the oldest mountain ranges in the world stretching about 300 miles from the northeast to the southwest. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The length of the Aravallis is about 1100 km which extends from Delhi to Ahmedabad. **Guru Shikhar is the highest point** which is located in Mount Abu. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- The Aravalli Range is very rich in natural resources and gave rise to numerous peninsula rivers like Banas, Luni, Sakhi, and Sabarmati.

93. (a)**Explanation:****Consumer Welfare Fund (CWF)**

- It was set up under the **Central Goods and Services Tax (CGST) Act, 2017**. The consumer welfare fund rules of 1992 have been subsumed under the CGST rules, 2017. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The Fund has been set up by the Department of Revenue (Ministry of Finance) and is **being operated by the Department of Consumer Affairs (Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution)**. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**

94. (a)**Explanation:**

- A Microfinance Institution (MFI) is an organization that offers financial services to low income populations.



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- MFIs are financial companies that provide small loans to **people who do not have any access to banking facilities. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- These services include microloans, microsavings and microinsurance.
 - The definition of “small loans” varies between countries. In India, all loans that are **below Rs.1 lakh can be considered as microloans. Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
- Microfinance sector has grown rapidly over the past few decades and currently it is serving around 102 million accounts (including banks and small finance banks) of the poor population of India.
- Non Banking Finance Company (NBFC)-MFIs in India are regulated by the **NBFC-MFI (Reserve Bank) Directions, 2011** of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) (**and not RBI Act, 1934**).

95. (a)**Explanation:**

- Shigmo festival is the spring festival in Goa celebrated by the Konkani diaspora of Goa, with a lot of pompous and splendour. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- Agricultural communities including the Kunbis, Gawdas and Velips celebrate the festival that also marks the onset of spring.
- Shigmo is celebrated all over India but in different names:
 - North India - Holi.
 - Assam and Bengal - Dolyatra.
 - South India - Kamadhan. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**
 - Maharashtra - Shimga.

96. (a)**Explanation:**

- The Suez Canal is an artificial sea-level waterway running north to south across the Isthmus of Suez in Egypt, to connect the **Mediterranean Sea and the Red Sea. Hence, option (a) is correct.**
- The canal separates the African continent from Asia.
- It provides the shortest maritime route between Europe and the lands lying around the Indian and western Pacific oceans.
- It is one of the world's most heavily used shipping lanes, carrying over 12% of world trade by volume.

**97. (c)****Explanation:**

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs, chaired by the Prime Minister of India, has approved the Government's plan to create and launch **India's first corporate bond Exchange Traded Fund (ETF) — Bharat Bond ETF.**

- The Fund will provide additional source of money for Central Public Sector Undertakings (CPSUs) Central Public Sector Enterprises (CPSEs), Central Public Financial Institutions (CPFIs) and other Government organizations to meet their borrowing requirements, apart from bank financing.

Exchange Traded Fund

- An Exchange-Traded Fund (ETF) is a **basket of securities that trade on an exchange**, just like a stock. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- ETF **reflects the composition of an Index**, like BSE Sensex. Its trading value is based on the Net Asset Value (NAV) of the underlying stocks (such as shares) that it represents.
- ETF share prices fluctuate all day as it is bought and sold. This is **different from mutual funds** that only trade once a day after the market closes.
- An ETF can own hundreds or thousands of stocks across various industries, or it could be isolated to one particular industry or sector.
- **Bond ETFs** are a type of ETFs which may include government bonds, corporate bonds, and state and local bonds—called municipal bonds.
 - **A bond** is an instrument that represents a loan made by an investor to a borrower (typically corporate or governmental).
- Besides being cost efficient, ETFs offer a diversified investment portfolio to investors.

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**Advantages**

- The Bharat Bond ETF will ensure **broader investor base** through the participation of retail and High Networth Individuals (HNI). This will lead to an increase in the demand for bonds, thus **reducing the cost of borrowing** for borrowers i.e. government organizations. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- The Bond ETF will provide safety, liquidity and predictable tax efficient returns.
- The launch of this ETF is expected to eventually **increase the size of bond ETFs in India** leading to achieving key objectives at a larger scale - deepening bond markets, enhancing retail participation and reducing borrowing costs.

98. (b)**Explanation:**

- Recently, the **Reserve Bank of India has proposed to allow retail investors to open gilt accounts** with the central bank to invest in **Government securities (G-secs)** directly and without the help of intermediaries.
- Government Security (G-Sec) is a tradable instrument issued **by the Central Government or the State Governments. Hence, statement 1 is NOT correct.**
- In India, the Central Government issues both treasury bills and bonds or dated securities while the State Governments issue only bonds or dated securities, which are called the **State Development Loans (SDLs). Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- G-Secs carry practically no risk of default and, hence, are called **risk-free gilt-edged instruments. Hence, statement 3 is correct.**
- **Gilt-edged securities are high-grade investment bonds** offered by governments and large corporations as a means of borrowing funds.

99. (b)**Explanation:**

- **Ways and Means Advances (WMA)** scheme was introduced in 1997 **to meet mismatches in the receipts and payments of the government. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The government **can avail immediate cash from the RBI**, if required. But it has to return the amount within 90 days. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

- Interest is charged at the existing repo rate.
 - Section 17(5) of the RBI Act, 1934 authorises the central bank to lend to the Centre and state governments subject to their being repayable “not later than three months from the date of the making of the advance”.
 - **Interest is charged at the existing repo rate.** If the WMA exceeds 90 days, it would be treated as an overdraft (the interest rate on overdrafts is 2 percentage points more than the repo rate). **Hence, statement 3 is NOT correct.**
- ◆ The limits for WMA (for Centre) are decided by the government and RBI mutually and revised periodically.
- ◆ A higher limit provides the government flexibility to raise funds from RBI without borrowing them from the market.
- There are two types of Ways and Means Advances — normal and special.
 - ◆ A Special WMA or Special Drawing Facility is provided against the collateral of the government securities held by the state.
 - ◆ After the state has exhausted the limit of SDF, it gets normal WMA.
 - ◆ The interest rate for SDF is one percentage point less than the repo rate.
 - ◆ The number of loans under normal WMA is based on a three-year average of actual revenue and capital expenditure of the state.

100. (c)**Explanation:****Kaziranga National Park:**

- It is located in the **State of Assam** and covers 42,996 Hectare (ha).
- It is the single largest undisturbed and representative area in the **Brahmaputra Valley floodplain.**
- It was declared as a **National Park in 1974.**
- It is recognized as an **Important Bird Area** by BirdLife International. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The park also has more than **250 seasonal water bodies**, besides the Diphlu River running through it. **Hence, statement 3 is correct.**
- As per the figures of tiger census conducted in 2014, **Kaziranga had an estimated 103 tigers**, the third-highest population in India after Jim Corbett National Park (215) in Uttarakhand and Bandipur National Park (120) in Karnataka. **Hence, statement 2 is NOT correct.**

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